

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 27 SEPTEMBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



NO TRAIN HAS CROSSED TO KANDY SINCE NOVEMBER. THE MONTH TO BOOK IS FEBRUARY (P21)

THE TRAVEL DESK

A cyclone obliterated six sections of track ten months ago, and the half that reopened is the half worth riding

THE RABBIT HOLE

Nine and a half millimetres: the gap a bee will neither glue shut nor build across, and the whole craft rests on it

THE ATELIER

Eleven of a hundred and sixty-two wrote properly out of the box, and Singapore is the cheap place to buy

THIS ISSUE · NO. 115

Contents

p3–4 The World — a seven-day plan, answered in four words from a driveway; three fronts open in Tigray
p5 Singapore — the super-aged line was crossed on Thursday, in a footnote
p6 The Atelier — fountain pens: whose nib is in your maker's pen, and why buying here is cheaper
p7 Technology — a rule that took effect two days before it was published
p8 The Home Lab — four times faster, on a chip most home rigs do not have
p9 The Kit — a Singapore launch price at last, and two features still in the post
p10 The Good Life — a hundred and sixty thousand euros, and no website to buy it from
p11 Screen & Sound — the record-breaking number one that is number two somewhere else

p12–13 The Family Desk — the ban moved where the phone is, not how much it is used
p14 The Macro Desk — three central banks hiked and the dollar declined to notice
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — beekeeping: the gap of nine and a half millimetres
p18 Fitness — stop asking what your VO2 max is; ask which way it is going
p19–22 The Travel Desk — book by Tuesday; Sri Lanka's hill country, and its broken line
p23–24 The Diary — a ballot already closed, and four kitchens too new to call
p25–27 The Long Read — jhut: the circular economy is being taken from Bangladesh
p28 The Last Word — the thresholds nobody announced

FROM THE DESK

"The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place."

William H. Whyte, *Fortune*, 1950 — the sentence for a week of announcements nobody made

A country crossed a demographic threshold in a footnote; a rule was enforced before it was printed; a railway has been severed for ten months and the brochures have not caught up.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year	5.06%	▲ 17bp wk
10-yr real	2.83%	▲ 21bp wk
VT (world eq.)	\$160.03	▲ 0.62%
BNDW	\$66.15	▲ 0.16%
DXY	100.755	▼ 0.26%
USD/SGD	1.2776	▼ 0.10%
USD/JPY	157.29	▼ 0.98%
Brent	\$104.45	▼ 2.02%
Gold	\$4,273.67	▲ 0.27%
Bitcoin	\$84,111	▲ 3.3% wk

Close of Friday 25 September. Caveats, the eleven-basis-point dispute over the ten-year, and a correction to No. 114's figure, on **p14**. Not advice.¹

THE ARCHIVE · WHAT NO. 115 IS STANDING ON

The Hormuz file. The memorandum whose expiry frames this week's rejected seven-day plan (**p3**) was signed in June and ran a sixty-day window that closed on 17 August. Its collapse has been tracked here since No. 95.

The Atelier's companion desk. Ink and paper were taught at No. 106 — two knobs, surface tension and viscosity. **p6** takes the instrument they run through, and finds the nib inside it was made by somebody else.

The destination ledger. Yesterday was Palawan. Sri Lanka's hill country is the forty-second deep dive, and the first to lead on a railway that is not running.

SOURCES 1 Levels at the close of Friday 25 September 2026, detailed with their sources on **p14**; the ten-year is the US Treasury's own par yield curve, and a widely-read quote page gives 5.17 for the same date. Fund levels are the verified US-listed lines, because a quoted price for the London all-world line was labelled in the wrong currency by its source.

THE MERIDIAN DISPATCH · SATURDAY

Seven days, priced at twelve billion dollars and a driveway answer

Tehran put a dated, sequenced offer on the table on Thursday: five days of American steps, the strait open on the sixth, talks on the seventh. Trump answered it standing outside the White House, in four words.

The offer had a calendar attached, which is what made it different. Iran's foreign minister **Abbas Araghchi** told reporters in New York on Thursday that Tehran had passed Washington a seven-day plan through Qatar, and then did the thing diplomats almost never do — he published the running order. American steps on days one to five. The Strait of Hormuz reopens on day six. Nuclear talks resume on day seven. “The seven-day timeline will start as soon as the United States accepts this plan.”¹

What Iran wanted for it: the naval blockade of its ports lifted, sanctions on its oil sales waived, roughly **twelve billion dollars** in frozen assets released, and a regional ceasefire that covered Lebanon and Yemen too. What it offered in return was the chokepoint and the table.¹

7

DAYS FROM ACCEPTANCE TO REOPENING — DAYS 1–5 AMERICAN, DAY 6 THE STRAIT, DAY 7 THE TALKS. ARAGHCHI HANDED IT TO STEVE WITKOFF AT THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY ON TUESDAY¹

On Saturday, outside the White House, the President gave the answer. “**I reject their proposal.**” Then: “They want to make a deal and I think that’s fine. I’d like to make a deal, too. But that deal would not be acceptable.” Iran, he said, wants one because it is “losing so badly.” In the same scrum he described the waterway in the first person plural: “We have total control of the Hormuz Strait. Massive amounts of oil are coming out.”²

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Prints the plan's terms in full and leads on Iranian initiative against American refusal, setting the offer against fuel prices running into an American electoral cycle — the framing in which Washington, not Tehran, holds the clock.³

BEIJING — XINHUA

Carries the rejection with no editorial line at all and lets the juxtaposition work: a conditional Iranian proposal beside a claim of ownership, and the possessive Trump sentence chosen over the others. Same day, separate prominent play for Araghchi calling West Asian security “integrated and indivisible” — the Saudi foreign minister, the Arab League, shipping lanes agreed with Oman. Force on one side of the ledger, consensus on the other.⁴

Iran's president **Masoud Pezeshkian**, interviewed the same day, was closing the door rather than holding it open: “We have no trust in the American side.” Any talks, he said, would have to run off the June memorandum — whose sixty-day window expired on **17 August** with nothing signed.⁵

THE CHATTER · THE CLOCK NOBODY NAMES

Burcu Ozelik, who researches Middle East security, reads the silence as tactics: “The US appears to believe it can wait this out until Tehran is prepared to make meaningful concessions.” **Urban Coningham** of RUSI gives the other wall in six words: “Hormuz is a clear Iranian red line.” Between the two sits no deal — an endurance test, and a diesel inventory.³

THE SCEPTIC · WORTH NOTHING ON ITS OWN TERMS

Thomas Warrick of the Atlantic Council declines to treat the week's largest diplomatic event as an event: the best outcome, he says, is that the offer “does lead to further discussions to try to clarify what preconditions Washington is willing to work with.” The ceiling is clarification, not agreement. The *Wall Street Journal*, at second hand, has him telling aides he expects to resume bombing after the midterms: which would make Saturday's four words a schedule, not a position.⁶

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera, “Iran says it awaits US response on seven-day roadmap” and “What’s in Iran’s seven-day plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz,” both 25 September 2026, read in full. 2 Al Jazeera, 26 September, on the South Lawn remarks; the “total control” sentence as Xinhua rendered the same scrum. 3 Al Jazeera explainer, 25 September, carrying Ozelik and Coningham. 4 Xinhua, three files of 26 September; no Chinese foreign-ministry comment appeared in any. 5 Al Jazeera interview with President Pezeshkian, aired 26 September; the window and its 17 August expiry per Xinhua. Al Jazeera dates the signing 17 June and Xinhua 18 June; a third rendering puts the venue in Pakistan, which this desk could not corroborate and does not print. 6 Al Jazeera, 26 September, carrying Warrick and Musgrave. The 28 February opening strikes and the one-fifth share are per Xinhua and Al Jazeera respectively. A figure of Brent above \$106 appeared on a section front and on no article page this desk could open, so it is absent here (p14).

AROUND THE DESKS • ETHIOPIA

Three fronts opened on Wednesday. The men who doubted the war were already in custody

Tigray's own leadership detained four veteran commanders the night before the offensive — among them the general who commanded the last one. The reported reason was that they had expressed doubts.

We reported the arrest of **Lt Gen Tadesse Werede** on Saturday. A correction and an escalation have arrived since. It happened overnight on **23–24 September**, and he was not taken alone: three other veteran commanders went with him, including **Col. Tewelde Gebretensay** of military intelligence. The fourth is unnamed. The reason reported is one clause — they “had expressed doubts about entering another war.”¹

Tadesse commanded the Tigray Defence Forces through the last war and had been under house arrest since the TPLF removed him in May. Armed men replaced the detail at his residence, penning his family in. **The next morning, three fronts opened** — two on the Amhara border, one on the Afar.²

21

AIRSTRIKES AT ALAMATA, DRONES AND MIG AIRCRAFT, **FOURTEEN CIVILIANS KILLED**. MEKELLE, AKSUM AND SHIRE AIRPORTS ARE SEIZED, ALL FLIGHTS SUSPENDED, AND EITREAN TROOPS HAVE ENTERED WESTERN TIGRAY.²

Two moves this weekend say what kind of war the participants think this is. TPLF forces, allied with the **Afar National Unity Revolutionary Front**, advanced into Zone 2 districts “with minimal resistance,” its commander **Ibrahim Osman Aliyu** assuring Afar residents the operation targeted only the federal government. And the Ethiopian Media Authority suspended **Tigray TV's licence indefinitely**, citing content that “threatens national and public security.” TPLF vice-president **Amanuel Assefa** has stopped hedging the noun: a “full-blown war.”³

THE CHATTER • SEVEN PARTIES, ONE AGREEMENT

Kjetil Tronvoll of Oslo New University College, on the alliance now facing Addis Ababa, states the whole of its common ground: “The only issue joining them is their opposition to Prosperity Party rule.” Seven parties, one shared negative. **Magnus Taylor** of the International Crisis Group and **Jalale Getachew Birru** of ACLED appear in the same reporting; none of it describes a shared war aim, or a settlement.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT A DARK REGION DOES TO A NUMBER

Every figure here comes out of a region whose telecoms have been down since ten at night on 22 September, whose three airports are shut, and whose last broadcaster has just been silenced. The fourteen dead, the twenty-one strikes, the “minimal resistance” — each is a claim from a belligerent or a monitor relaying one, and this desk reached none directly: the detention reporting is Reuters, readable here only through two aggregators. **What would settle it:** an independent count. Until there is one, the precision belongs to the reporting chain, not the ground.⁵

IN BRIEF

The UN's settlement-business database grew by 61 companies on Thursday, to **214 firms in eleven countries**; new entries include Spain's Salvat Logistica and Israel's Alony Hetz.⁶

Diesel is where the Gulf war reaches an American forecourt. US retail diesel hit **\$6.50 a gallon** on Thursday against \$5.61 in August, on **107.9 million barrels** of inventory — the thinnest in four decades.⁷

Four Iraqi airports stopped Iranian flights from Thursday under new American aviation sanctions; the UAE followed. Baghdad wants an exemption “on humanitarian grounds related to medical treatment, education, religious visits.”⁸

Pope Leo XIV, at the Élysée on Thursday: “If we are to avoid losing our humanity amid a paradise of machines invading and conditioning our lives, there is an urgent need for education in ethical discernment.”⁹

SOURCES 1 Reuters on the detentions, reached via Martin Plaut's Horn of Africa file and Kulu Media, 24–25 September 2026. 2 EEPA Situation Report No. 764, 24 September, and the Ethiopia conflict live file, 25 September. 3 The same live file, 25–26 September, for the ANURF advance, the Tigray TV suspension and Amanuel Assefa. 4 “Ethiopia's new rebel alliance faces an old problem,” 26 September, carrying Tronvoll, Taylor and Birru. 5 This desk's own account of its reach: reuters.com is refused here, so its copy was read through aggregators, and no figure on this page was checked against an independent count. 6 UN human rights office, 25 September 2026. 7 Al Jazeera on a US diesel export ban, 25 September. 8 Al Jazeera, 26 September. 9 Al Jazeera, 25 September, quoting the Élysée address.

THE LITTLE RED DOT · THURSDAY

Singapore became a super-aged society on Thursday. The threshold is in footnote nine

Twenty-one point four per cent of citizens are now sixty-five or older, and the United Nations line is twenty-one. Nobody said so out loud: the milestone arrived inside a PDF, under a chart, on a weekday afternoon.

Population in Brief 2026 went up on Thursday and reported that **21.4 per cent** of Singapore citizens were sixty-five or over in June, against 20.7 a year ago and **13.7 in 2016**. Footnote nine, on the same page, supplies the rest: “The United Nations defines a country as ‘super aged’ once the share of its population aged 65 and above reaches 21%.”¹

2.8

CITIZENS AGED 20–64 FOR EVERY CITIZEN OVER 65, DOWN FROM **4.7 IN 2016**. THE REPORT’S OWN PROJECTION: 2.4 BY 2030 AND **2.2 BY 2035**¹

The line was crossed, and the document that records it keeps the phrase out of its own headline text — a civilisational marker filed as an annotation, which is a very Singaporean way to pass one. The rest of the tables read the same story from other ends. Citizens over eighty: **152,000**, up sixty per cent in a decade. Median age **44.1**. Resident fertility **0.87** for 2025, from 0.97 — a record low. Citizen births **26,071**, down **10.8 per cent** in one year. Marriages down 5.6.¹

And yet the total population rose 1.6 per cent to **6,208,500**, and the citizen population rose too, by 0.7 per cent. The report is unusually direct about why the headline number grew: chiefly more **Work Permit Holders in construction**, for “key projects such as Changi Terminal 5” and the Marina Bay Sands expansion.¹

THE CHATTER · TWO NUMBERS THAT BELONG IN THE SAME SENTENCE

Set Thursday’s report beside two prints from the same week. On Wednesday **twenty-three financial institutions** pledged to train more than **80,000** Singapore-based staff in AI skills by 2028.² Meanwhile entry-level pay rose 2.5 per cent while entry-level *headcount* fell 3.2, and graduates employed within six months slipped to **83.4 per cent** from 87.1.³ Fewer children, fewer first jobs, more retraining.

THE SCEPTIC · THE CITIZEN NUMBER IS A NATURALISATION NUMBER

The labour economist **Walter Theseira** punctures the growth reading: demand for foreign workers “is concentrated in sectors such as construction and domestic work,” and an ageing population itself generates the care demand. The country did not become more populous in any sense a citizen would notice; it built a terminal and got older.⁴ The harder point needs only the report’s own figures: births fell 10.8 per cent and marriages 5.6, yet the citizen count rose 0.7 — carried by **25,094 new citizenships**. Immigration, the document says, “keeps the citizen population from shrinking” — the honest way of saying the growth line is an intake line.¹

IN BRIEF

Two Supreme Court appointments take effect Thursday: **Justice Hoo Sheau Peng** to the Court of Appeal, and **Mr Goh Yihan SC**, Deputy Attorney-General since January 2025, to the Appellate Division.⁵

The haze returned on Saturday. NEA’s evening advisory had 24-hour PSI at **71–96**, forecast “moderate to low unhealthy”; later readings put central Singapore at **104**, into Unhealthy. Kalimantan fires, and dry conditions holding.⁶

SOURCES 1 *Population in Brief 2026*, National Population and Talent Division, published 25 September 2026; the PDF was downloaded and read in full, including footnote 9 and Table 5. All figures are as at June 2026 except vital statistics, which are for calendar 2025. 2 South China Morning Post, 24 September 2026, reporting the banking-and-finance dinner. 3 South China Morning Post, 23 September 2026, on Aon data published in August and the six autonomous universities’ joint graduate survey. 4 Malay Mail / AFP, 26 September 2026, quoting Walter Theseira; the quotation is short and single-sourced and is given exactly. A second academic is cited in the same piece without a direct quotation, so none is printed. 5 Prime Minister’s Office, appointment of Supreme Court judges, 25 September 2026. 6 NEA haze situation update, 26 September 2026; the later readings via AsiaOne the same evening — the two sets differ because they are different hours, which is why both are given. 7 August 2026 CPI, released 23 September, read via Trading Economics; singstat and mas.gov.sg are refused here. No r/singapore material is on this page: reddit.com refused at both layers and nine mirrors returned 403, 429 or a bot challenge.

BUY IT ONCE · FOUNTAIN PENS, THE PEN ITSELF

Eleven of a hundred and sixty-two wrote properly out of the box

The ink and the paper were settled at No. 106. The instrument is a harder argument, because the part that touches the page is the same welded pellet on a forty-dollar pen and a four-thousand-dollar one — and the one category where Singapore is thirty per cent cheaper than America.

Start at the tip, because everything else is negotiable and this is not. Platinum's own engineering page describes it: a powder of **iridium and osmium** is "instantaneously heated," formed into a rounded pellet and **welded** to the nib, then slit and polished. That pellet is the writing surface, and it is the same class of material whether the nib behind it is steel or gold.¹

So what does gold buy? Platinum answers plainly: 14k is **58.5 per cent gold** with silver, copper and nickel, chosen for "resistance to the acid of the ink" and "the desired stiffness."¹ Franklin-Christoph, which sells gold, inverts the usual assumption on its own page: **14k is springier than 18k**, which is softer and wetter — and modern steel carries "the same iridium tipping."²

6.8%

OF NEW VISCONTIS ONE SELLER FOUND ACCEPTABLE OUT OF THE BOX — **ELEVEN OF 162** HANDLED OVER EIGHTEEN MONTHS, POSTED TO THE FOUNTAIN PEN NETWORK³

Now the white label, which is this desk's beat. Two German houses make most of the nibs sold under other people's names. The tell is accidental: a retailer's listing warns that JoWo is changing its nib engraving, so "**what you receive may not necessarily match what is photographed**" — a supplier's die change propagating through a maker's own product shots.⁴

The bespoke route is real and its waits are published. Edison's Collier is **US\$275** in steel, **US\$475** in 18k, backlog "4 to 16 weeks"; **Newton Pens** is closed to new orders; **Conid's** own page says its pens "can not be ordered at the moment." And **Hakase** of Tottori, which measures your handwriting in the workshop, publishes the wait as a number: **twenty-**

six to thirty months, paid in full up front. Its arithmetic is not mystique but division — ten pens a month, a hundred and twenty back orders. **Nakaya**, founded in 1999 by Platinum's president, makes the other case: "**tuning of the nib as many times as needed**", free, forever.⁵

SINGAPORE · THE ARITHMETIC RUNS THE OTHER WAY HERE

This desk usually finds the local price is the tax. Not here. **Aesthetic Bay** lists the **Pilot Custom 823** at **SGD 458**. American street is about SGD 531 and the US list **SGD 664** — so buying here is roughly **14 per cent under American street and 31 under list**, before shipping and GST on an import.⁶ **Sunny Koh at Straits Pen** charges **SGD 80** a grind, "between 10 and 40 minutes" while you wait, and nothing to realign or flush a nib.⁷

THE SCEPTIC · THE GOLD MARKUP, AND WHAT THE TROPICS BREAK

Four Fountain Pen Network threads reach one finding. **Mercian**: modern stainless means "there is **no reason why there should be any functional/performance difference**" between a stiff steel nib and a stiff gold one. **AAAndrew**: "the only difference of two stiff nibs is aesthetics. **Urushi is the tropical material**: it *cures* at 20–25°C and 65–85 per cent humidity, which is Singapore."⁸

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Shaving brushes — knot density, backbone, and the synthetics that caught the badger.

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — Nambu ironware, and the iron-water claim tested.

Chopping knives for the tropics — why carbon steel behaves differently at eighty per cent humidity.

SOURCES 1 Platinum Pen's own engineering page, read 26 September 2026. 2 Franklin-Christoph's #6 nib-unit page. 3 FPN thread 375971, opened 30 July 2024; the 11-of-162 figure is a named seller's own count and is community testimony, not audited data. 4 Retailer compatibility guides at Goldspot and Iguana Sell; neither JoWo nor Bock has a reachable corporate site. Franklin-Christoph and Edison nib pages; Conid's news archive. 5 Edison's Collier page; Newton Pens' lineup; Conid's product page; Hakase's own price and order pages; Nakaya's custom-order and repair pages. 6 Aesthetic Bay and Cityluxe against Goulet and Pen Chalet, at the ECB's 25 September rate of 1 USD = 1.2771 SGD. 7 Straits Pen's service page, prices effective 1 September 2026. FPN threads 374873, 331202, 188042 and 202645. FPN thread 380473, opened 16 January 2026. 8 Fountain Pen Chronicles and FPNRevolution; the urushi window is corroborated by Pilot's own Custom 845 copy. **Held**: Dan Smith's and John Mottishaw's prices could not be read — one host refuses this desk, the other lists every grind sold out at zero — so neither is quoted.

SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY · THURSDAY

A rule that took effect two days before anyone could read it

Commerce made stockpiling polysilicon an import offence, backdated the start, and set the weekly allowance for a new importer at twelve kilogrammes. The material it invokes national security to protect is 2.4 per cent of the trade it regulates.

The Bureau of Industry and Security published a temporary final rule on Thursday restricting imports of polysilicon by anyone it judges to be stockpiling. Its own dates paragraph reads: “This rule is effective September 22, 2026, through December 3, 2026.” It was published on the 24th. There was no comment period.¹

What it polices is the run-up to **4 December**, when minimum import prices bite: **\$21 a kilo** for polysilicon, \$100 for ingots and wafers, 22 cents a watt for cells, 38 for modules. The rule watches whether an importer is moving volumes “substantially greater than their historic averages,” against four separate baselines.¹

12 kg

THE WEEKLY CEILING ON HIGH-PURITY SILICON FOR AN IMPORTER OF RECORD REGISTERED SINCE 6 AUGUST. PHOTOVOLTAIC CELLS IN MODULES: FIFTY-FIVE UNITS A WEEK¹

The justification is written into the proclamation behind it: polysilicon is “the base material for semiconductors... necessary to the function of the United States military.” It records the American share of global polysilicon capacity falling from **50 per cent in 2005 to under 2 in 2024**.²

Two details complicate it. The rule draws **no line between semiconductor-grade and solar-grade** material — every listed tariff code carries the same restriction — and it names no country. And semiconductor-grade is **2.4 per cent** of global polysilicon production.²

A rule written for the defence industrial base may damage the two-point-four per cent of the trade that the defence industrial base actually uses.

THE CHATTER · THE TRAP IN THE SCALE

Christopher Gundermann and **Ray Cai** of CSIS set out the mechanism three weeks ago. Makers of ultra-pure semiconductor-grade polysilicon “depend on the significantly higher demand volume of the broader solar-grade polysilicon market to sustain the necessary economies of scale” — so measures that suppress solar demand “may also harm U.S. semiconductor-grade polysilicon manufacturing.” Their price arithmetic is the other half: a **\$21 floor** against a global average of **\$5.27** in January, and 22 cents a watt for cells against 5.8. American production costs, they write, were “nearly five times those in China.”³

THE SCEPTIC · THE INDUSTRY THE RULE IS FOR

Tim Pawlenty, who runs the Solar Energy Industries Association, put his objection in the register of a man who expects to be ignored: “America has made terrific progress rebuilding its solar manufacturing base, but imposing tariffs and price floors on solar materials will create new challenges for American manufacturers and raise energy costs for families and businesses.” **Intertek CEA** quantifies it — domestic module prices to about **35 cents a watt**, with utility-scale cancellations expected.⁴ CSIS is blunter still: “prior attempts to protect the U.S. polysilicon industry through trade measures alone have been largely unsuccessful,” and this one “is also unlikely to succeed without additional domestic incentives.”³ **What would falsify the pessimism:** a waiver record.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Micron reports on Wednesday, 2.30pm Mountain time — three days past this issue, with no guidance figures published.⁵

No stay is on the record in the two Munich YMTC injunctions. Micron has appealed and filed its own infringement action; two further utility-model cases were adjourned, and the injunctions remain enforceable.⁶

SOURCES 1 “Measures To Restrict Stockpiling of Polysilicon and Polysilicon Derivatives Under Proclamation 11052,” Bureau of Industry and Security, temporary final rule, 91 FR 60505, published 24 September 2026; full text read at federalregister.gov, including the DATES paragraph, the monitoring criteria and the per-code weekly limits. 2 Proclamation 11052, signed 6 August 2026, 91 FR 51975, read in full. 3 Christopher Gundermann and Ray Cai, “Polysilicon and the Merits of Trade Measures as Industrial Policy,” CSIS, 8 September 2026 — note it pre-dates Thursday’s rule and addresses the August proclamation. 4 *pv magazine USA*, Ryan Kennedy, 14 August 2026, carrying the Pawlenty statement in full and the Intertek CEA estimate. 5 Micron’s own notice of results, 26 August 2026. 6 JUVE Patent, Konstanze Richter, 24 September 2026, on Landgericht München I, 7th Civil Chamber; no bond figure or product list could be read, and one trade report is paywalled. 7 CourtListener’s search record for D.C. Cir. Nos. 26-1049 and 26-1162; the HTML docket returned 403 and the entries API 401, so “nothing since” means nothing visible in the search record, not a certified docket read.

THE HOME LAB • MERGED SATURDAY

Four times faster, on a chip most home labs do not have

A tiling rewrite of the CPU matrix multiply landed in `llama.cpp` this weekend. The headline is a four-fold prefill gain; on the instruction set in most second-hand rigs it is one-point-seven.

Pull request [#27851](#) was opened on 28 August and merged on Saturday after forty commits. The author, [jbooth](#), describes the insight in one sentence: “the `vec_dot` approach currently taken for `mul_mat` duplicates the work of unpacking quants a bunch of times.” His fix unpacks quantised weights once into **256×256 int8 tiles**, amortising that work 256-fold, and computes each output tile in a 16×16 microkernel before touching main memory.¹

On an AMD 9950X3D with VNNI, eight threads, the microbenchmark runs **3.8×** on `q2_K` and **6.9×** on `q5_K`. End to end — a 27-billion-parameter model at `Q5_K`, prompt of 2,048 — prefill goes from **16.3 to 67.1 tokens a second**.¹

1.7×

THE SAME END-TO-END GAIN ON **AVX2** — EVERY ZEN 2 AND ZEN 3 PART, EVERY PRE-ICE-LAKE INTEL, AND THE WIDE MIDDLE OF THE SECOND-HAND-XEON CROWD: 15.0 TO 25.4 TOKENS A SECOND¹

Approved by [ggerganov](#), [bartowski1182](#) and [taroneao](#), the last of whom had asked for exactly the end-to-end table the author eventually posted. A request for wider VNNI support was deferred as a follow-up to keep the review tractable, and it went in as written.¹

THE CHATTER • THE OTHER MERGE, AND WHAT OWNERS MEASURED

Two days earlier the Vulkan backend got int8 tensor cores on AMD — PR [#27952](#) by [Occ4m](#), replacing the FP16 dequant path across thirteen quant formats. Post-merge reports from owners: a Strix Halo machine **+27 per cent** on `IQ4_XS` prefill at 3,461 tokens; an RX 7900 XTX **+47 per cent** on a 512-token MXFP4 prefill. An RX 7800 XT saw a modest prefill gain offset by a decode regression under speculative decoding. On an RX 7900XT, [@edt-xx](#) was refreshingly unwilling to claim more than he had: “There is too much variance in token gen to say anything. This has positive effects in a real use case.” Five formats fall back to FP16 because testing found the int8 path slower.²

THE SCEPTIC • READ WHICH NUMBER IS WHICH

Three caveats the banner does not carry. First, the four-fold figure is a **VNNI** number, and AVX512-VNNI is not what most home labs run; on AVX2 the microbenchmark spread is 1.16× to 2.09×. Second, this is a **prefill** win — a prompt-processing measurement at 2,048 tokens, which does nothing for token generation, the thing people actually complain about. Third, the accuracy cost is small but real and unbudgeted: the author reports max single-scalar error around **5e-04** and RMSE about 6e-05 against the standard path, which now runs by default. **Nobody in the thread published a perplexity or KLD check**. That is the test that would settle it, and it has not been run.¹

IN BRIEF

llama.cpp has a version number again — bumped to **0.5.0** on Wednesday, by [ggerganov](#), with zero comments on the pull request.³

Home Assistant: nothing this week. The current release is still 2026.9, from 2 September; on the first-Wednesday cadence, 2026.10 is due about 7 October. No Matter or Thread specification release appeared in the window either.⁴

Thirty-one pull requests merged into `llama.cpp` in the eight days to Saturday, among them a Qualcomm-authored hexagon path for gated delta networks and CUDA flash-attention tuning for Ampere and later.⁵

SOURCES 1 [ggml-org/llama.cpp pull request #27851](#), “ggml-cpu: tiled mul_mat for k-quants,” opened 28 August 2026 and merged 26 September 2026 at commit d834d44; the benchmark tables, the accuracy figures and every quotation were read in the pull request itself. 2 Pull request [#27952](#), “vulkan: int8 coopmat1 matmul implementation for AMD RDNA3 and RDNA4,” merged 24 September 2026, including the post-merge owner reports in its comment thread. 3 Pull request [#29333](#), 23 September 2026. 4 [home-assistant.io release notes index](#); the newest entry is 2026.9, 2 September 2026. 5 GitHub pull-request search over [ggml-org/llama.cpp](#), merged 19–27 September 2026, thirty-one results.

GEAR WE'RE WATCHING • ON SALE WEDNESDAY

Six hundred and sixty-nine dollars, and Singapore is a launch market for once

The third-generation Ray-Ban Meta went on sale here the day it was announced, with a published Singapore price. Two of its three headline features are not in the box yet, and the number a buyer will test first has never been independently measured.

The gap No. 114 had to leave blank — a launch with no Singapore price — closed on Wednesday. Meta's third-generation Ray-Ban glasses went on sale at **US\$449**, and the Singapore page carries **SGD 669**, inclusive of GST. Singapore, South Korea, Mexico and the UAE were launch markets on day one.¹

The specification, from the maker: a single **12-megapixel** camera shooting 3K video with a built-in recording LED; **32 GB** of storage, which Meta rates at about a thousand photographs; a **six-microphone array** it says cuts more than ninety per cent of background noise; Bluetooth 5.3; a customisable action button; and twenty-seven colour and lens combinations across Aviator, Wayfarer and the cat-eye Zena. Battery: **"up to nine hours... an hour more than Gen 2,"** with fifty more in the case.¹

~5 h

WHAT A REVIEWER ACTUALLY MEASURED ON THE PREVIOUS GENERATION WITH CONTINUOUS AUDIO — AGAINST META'S EIGHT-HOUR CLAIM FOR IT. THERE IS NO INDEPENDENT MEASUREMENT OF THE NINE-HOUR CLAIM AT ALL²

That reviewer is **Karissa Bell**, who had the Aviators in hand on launch day and is careful about what she has and has not tested. On price, three words: "a bit of a price hike."²

THE CHATTER • THERE ISN'T ONE, AND THAT IS THE ENTRY

This box normally carries what owners say. Four days after launch there are no owners writing anywhere this desk could reach: Reddit refused at every route tried, and the only comparison writing published in the window is an aggregation piece with no owner experience in it. So the honest state of the community read on this product is **empty**, and a buyer deciding this weekend is deciding on a press release and one hands-on. That is worth knowing before you spend six hundred and sixty-nine dollars on a first weekend.

THE SCEPTIC • TWO OF THE THREE HEADLINE FEATURES ARE IOUS

Dolby Atmos spatial capture ships "later in 2026" — not at launch. Landscape photo and video capture was **not available to reviewers** on launch day. That leaves the nine-hour battery as the one headline feature you can test on Wednesday, and it is the one with no independent number behind it; the nearest measurement in existence is five hours on the model this supposedly beats by an hour.² And the second arithmetic: US\$449 becomes SGD 669.

IN BRIEF

Ray-Ban Meta Audio, US\$349, ships 13 October — Meta's first camera-free glasses, **43 grams**, rated up to twelve hours with forty-eight more in the case, in Clubmaster and Burbank. *No Singapore price has been published; it is absent from the Singapore page entirely.*¹

Meta Adventurer, US\$249, on sale 23 October — the cheapest entry in the line. The Singapore site lists the Meta Glasses category from **SGD 349**, which is a category price, not this model's.¹

Hearing enhancement, cleared by the FDA, at US\$149.99 for adults with perceived mild-to-moderate loss, or bundled with a subscription. United States only, later this year — no Singapore path announced.³

The Display model expands to five more countries. The United Kingdom, Canada, France, Italy and Germany; Singapore is not on the list. Meta says it will offer more than a hundred options across Ray-Ban, Oakley and its own line by the end of the year.³

SOURCES 1 "Introducing Ray-Ban Meta Audio and More AI Glasses Styles," Meta newsroom, 23 September 2026, read in full; the SGD 669 figure read twice on Meta's own Singapore product page, and the specification corroborated at Notebookcheck, 24 September. No water-resistance rating and no weight for the Gen 3 was published by either, so none is printed. 2 Engadget hands-on, Karissa Bell, 23 September 2026. 3 Meta newsroom, "The biggest news from Connect 2026," 24 September 2026. No owner forum is cited on this page because none could be reached: reddit.com refused at both layers and the one mirror tried returned 429.

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · FRIDAY

A hundred and sixty thousand euros, eighteen pieces, and no website to buy it from

Minerva has stepped out from under Montblanc to stand on its own name after a hundred and sixty-eight years. Its first move as an independent house is a suspended tourbillon in yellow gold — and a domain that does not resolve.

The object first. Reference **137548**: a 44.8 by 15.03 millimetre case in polished 18-carat yellow gold, stepped lugs, onion crown, domed sapphire. The dial is deep olive-green guilloché with an off-centred hours-and-minutes sub-dial in **black onyx** at twelve, and below it the mechanism the piece exists for.¹

Calibre **M16.68**, hand-wound, **218 components**, nineteen jewels, beating at a slow **18,000 vibrations an hour** for about fifty hours. The balance is **14.5 millimetres** across with eighteen regulating screws, and it is *suspended* — sitting above the rotating cage rather than inside it, which is the patent. Eighteen pieces. **160,000 euros**.¹

1858

THE YEAR ON THE DIAL, AND THE HOUSE HAS JUST STOPPED SHARING A SIGNATURE. MINERVA NOW TRADES AS A STAND-ALONE NAME — AND **MINERVA1858.COM DOES NOT RESOLVE**¹

That last fact is the story, not a gap in the reporting. A manufacture relaunching independently at six figures, in a run of eighteen, with no reachable site of its own and its former parent's Singapore page returning a server error, is making a distribution decision as much as a horological one. Where you would go to be told about this watch does not exist yet.

Eighteen pieces from a house with no live website is a question about how you are meant to find it, not about the tourbillon.

THE CHATTER · ONE VOICE, AND IT IS FAVOURABLE

The enthusiast press has seen it; collectors have not spoken. **Denis Peshkov** at Monochrome, who published the first look on Friday, reads the piece as a single coherent idea rather than a specification — the mechanism, the large yellow-gold case, the onyx and the olive green pulled into one statement — and notes the presentation box carries “two olive branches made using hand-applied gold leaf.” He offers no criticism. This desk found **no collector forum voice anywhere**: WatchUSeek and the audio boards were unreachable and Reddit refused. For an eighteen-piece launch four days old, silence is the expected state, and we will not invent a consensus that has not formed.¹

THE SCEPTIC · BORROWED FROM THE WATCH NEXT TO IT

No critic has taken on the Minerva yet, so the sceptic runs from the week's other launch, where one has. At that distance from an AP, the Breguet is competing on a field it did not choose; he allows only that the titanium versions are “priced competitively.”² The structural line on the Minerva needs no critic, only the spec sheet: a **44.8mm solid-gold case rated to 30 metres**, fifty hours at 18,000 beats.

STILL ON THE BENCH

Breguet's Marine grows to twelve references. The **5517** time-and-date at 40mm by 11.5, calibre 777A, 55 hours; the **5527** flyback chronograph at 42.3 by 13.85, calibre 582QA, 48 hours. Both 100 metres, in titanium and 18-carat rose or white gold, with Breguet numerals replacing the Romans.²

The references, for the record. The 5517 runs as 5517BB, 5517BR and 5517TI; the 5527 chronograph as 5527BB, 5527BR and 5527TI, each in two dial executions. Both carry a Quai de l'Horloge guilloché dial with an applied chapter ring, and “apple” hands with luminous fill.²

Favre Leuba added black and blue dials to the Harpoon Revival on Friday. References and prices were not published in the coverage this desk could read, so none appear here.³

A local date rather than an object: Audemars Piguet ran a padel event in Singapore across this weekend, 25 to 27 September.³

SOURCES 1 Monochrome Watches, Denis Peshkov, “First Look: The Olive Green Minerva Exo Tourbillon Limited Edition 18,” 25 September 2026, read in full — the reference, the dimensions, the calibre specification and the 160,000-euro price are all from that page and the price is **single-sourced**. No maker's page could be read: minerva1858.com returns no DNS record and montblanc.com's Singapore site returned 503. No delivery window, ordering mechanism or Singapore price has been published. 2 SJX Watches, Jack Shepherdson, 26 September 2026, on the Marine 5517 and 5527. 3 Monochrome, Brice Goulard, 25 September, on the Harpoon Revival; SJX, 24 September, for the Singapore event. No owner or collector sentiment is quoted on this page because none was reachable.

CULTURE DESK · THE WEEKEND'S CHARTS

The longest number-one run in the history of the Hot 100 is sitting at number two in Britain

Ella Langley's twenty-third week at the top of one chart is the same week she spends beaten on another. Both numbers are correct; naming the chart is the whole job.

On the Billboard Hot 100 dated yesterday, “Choosin’ Texas” spends its **twenty-third week** at number one — the longest reign in the chart’s history, past Mariah Carey. On the Official UK Singles Chart covering the same seven days, Ella Langley is at **number two**, and has been for at least a fortnight, behind **Sienna Spiro’s “Great Expectation”** in its third week on top.¹

Setting the record straight: No. 114 printed Langley’s twenty-third week without naming which chart it belonged to. The number was right; the chart was unstated, and on a page that usually carries the British listing a Singapore reader would reasonably have read it as the British one. It is the American chart.

1

WEEK ON CHART FOR **BEABADOOBEE’S PYLON**, STRAIGHT IN AT THE TOP OF THE UK ALBUMS CHART — HER SECOND BRITISH NUMBER-ONE ALBUM, AND NUMBER ONE IN AUSTRALIA THE SAME WEEK²

Released on 18 September on Dirty Hit, *Pylon* is her fourth record and carries Chino Moreno, Hayley Williams and Brendan Yates as guests. Behind it the albums chart is a museum: Michael Jackson’s *The Essential* at two in its **277th week**, Olivia Dean’s *The Art of Loving* at five in its 52nd.¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT A CRITIC SAID, AND WHAT WE COULD NOT READ

One review of *Pylon* was readable at source this weekend, and it is unreserved — **Ratings Game Music**, four and a half out of five: “*Pylon* gives and gives and gives some more. It reverberates through your body and lives rent-free in your brain.” Three other named critics surfaced — at *Pitchfork*, *Uncut* and *The Line of Best Fit*, the last of whom filed under the headline “Londoner’s fourth album brings the noise, gently” — but every aggregator this desk tried refused it. **So no aggregate score for this album is printed here**, and one enthusiastic review is not a consensus.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE BIGGEST FILM OF FRIDAY WAS SEVEN YEARS OLD

Two original wide releases opened on Friday. ***Heart of the Beast***, David Ayer directing Brad Pitt, took **\$7.45m** on 3,435 screens with 87 per cent from 141 critics. ***Forgotten Island*** took **\$4.38m** on 3,548. And a re-release of ***Avengers: Endgame***, on fewer screens than either at 3,060, took **\$11.2m** — more than both new originals combined.⁴ The distribution economics of a Friday in September now favour a film the audience has already seen over the two it has not. **What would falsify it:** the Sunday actuals, and whether either original holds next weekend against a library title with no marketing spend left to make.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Primetime went wide on Friday — Lance Oppenheim directing Robert Pattinson, from A24. It holds **87 per cent** on Rotten Tomatoes and **67** on Metacritic, with at least one critic down at 35: a film the aggregate likes considerably more than its harshest reader does.⁵

Last weekend, for the hold comparison: *Resident Evil* opened at **\$60.2m** on 3,684 screens; *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* passed **\$944m** worldwide in its eighth week and *The Odyssey* **\$609.8m** in its tenth.⁴

No tour announcement and no award is printed this week. Two trade outlets that would have carried them redirect to paywalls this desk cannot open, and an unverified date is worse than a short page.

SOURCES 1 Official Charts Company, singles and albums charts dated 25 September to 1 October 2026, read at officialcharts.com, with the chart dated 18–24 September read separately to confirm the two-week position. 2 Billboard Hot 100 and Billboard 200 for the issue dated 26 September 2026, reached through the Wikipedia current-chart pages rather than billboard.com, which refuses this desk; the “longest-reigning chart-topper in Hot 100 history” characterisation is that page’s. The issue dated 3 October publishes on Tuesday, after this edition. 3 Ratings Game Music, 17 September 2026. Metacritic, Album of the Year, Any Decent Music and *Pitchfork* all refused this desk, so no aggregate is given; the other three critics are named from search listings and were not read. 4 Box Office Mojo daily grosses for Friday 25 September 2026 and the weekend of 18–20 September. 5 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic pages for *Primetime*.

RAISING THEM WELL · THE EVIDENCE AT TWELVE

The world's first under-sixteen social media ban is nine months old. For twelve-year-olds it changed almost nothing

Australia switched it on last December. The first peer-reviewed evaluation, split by age band, finds the twelve-to-thirteens barely moved – and the over-sixteens used more.

Australia's ban took effect on **10 December 2025**. Burrows and colleagues surveyed more than four hundred young social-media users immediately before it and again three months after, and split the results into three bands. **Twelve to thirteen: little change. Fourteen to fifteen: a slight decrease. Sixteen and over: use went up.** The authors' own conclusion is that they found "insufficient evidence to conclude that exposure to the Act had any early substantial effects."¹

The regulator's own numbers are blunter. Before the ban, **86 per cent** of ten- to fifteen-year-olds used social media; three months after, **81 per cent** still did. Daily use went from about sixty per cent to **58**. Some **4.7 million** child accounts were revoked by mid-January – and roughly half the children who kept theirs kept them because the platform never checked.²

-0.48

THE ADJUSTED MEAN DIFFERENCE IN MENTAL WELLBEING BETWEEN RESTRICTIVE AND PERMISSIVE SCHOOLS IN THE ENGLISH PHONE-BAN STUDY – **95% CI -2.05 TO 1.06, P = 0.62**. A NOTHING, MEASURED CAREFULLY³

That English study is the useful companion, because it is about phones rather than platforms and it lands on the same finding by a different road. Goodyear and colleagues surveyed **1,227 pupils aged twelve to fifteen across thirty secondary schools**. Restrictive schools did cut phone use *in school* – by 0.67 hours a day, solidly significant – and made **no difference at all to total weekly use**. More phone and social-media time was associated with worse mental health. The schools moved where the phone was, not how much it was used.³

Bans move where the phone is. They do not move how much the phone is used – and it is total use, not school use, that tracks the harm.

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST, AND HERE IS THE MEASUREMENT

The strongest counterweight is not a claim that screens are harmless. It is a measurement of how small the association is. **Amy Orben** and **Andrew Przybylski**, running specification curves across three large datasets totalling **355,358 young people**, found the link between digital technology use and adolescent wellbeing negative but trivial – explaining **at most 0.4 per cent** of the variation. Their summary: effects are "small at best, reciprocal over time, gender specific, and contingent on analytic methods." A 2026 replication in *Acta Psychologica* reports most specifications negative but some *positive* – social-media time correlating with more vigorous physical activity among boys.⁵ Be fair to the other side too: a rebuttal by Sigaud, Rausch, McClean and Haidt is in press at *Clinical Psychological Science*, arguing three of the studies in this line should not be used to assess social media's impact at all.

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE PARENTS, ON THE RECORD, ABOUT THIS EXACT AGE

Singapore's own rules came in this January: secondary students may not use phones or smartwatches during school hours *at all* – recess, CCAs and supplementary lessons included – with devices in lockers or bags, and the school laptop's nightly lock moved from eleven to **ten-thirty**. A study published as it started collected what parents actually expect. **Ms Yvette Lim**, whose child was entering Secondary 1, had heard of parents handing over **a dummy phone** so the child keeps the real one. A teacher of ten years reports "a sense of growing anxiety" among parents; a former one notes that "teachers can't be everywhere all at once."⁴

SOURCES 1 Burrows et al., *BMJ*, 25 June 2026, doi 10.1136/bmj-2026-100046. **bmj.com is refused to this desk**, so the design, the bands, the sample and the conclusion come from secondary reporting of the paper, consistent across two accounts; treat the effect estimates as unread at source. 2 eSafety figures as reported 3 August 2026; the regulator's own newsroom returned 503. 3 Goodyear et al., "SMART Schools," *The Lancet Regional Health – Europe*, 4 February 2025, read at PubMed Central. Cross-sectional, so no causal claim; school response rate was 8.7–10.4 per cent, which is a real selection worry, and use was self-reported. A 2026 NBER working paper on American school bans reaches the same null and calls itself underpowered. Ministry of Education measures announced 30 November 2025, in force January 2026; MOE's own release page renders blank to this desk and was read through secondary coverage and the NIE study. National Institute of Education, Nanyang Technological University, 3 December 2025 – all parents named on the record in that piece. 5 Orben and Przybylski, *Nature Human Behaviour* 2019 and *Scientific Reports* 2020; Whelan, *Acta Psychologica*, online 15 April 2026, PMID 41990469, whose abstract this desk could not open at source.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE CONVERSATION YOU HAVE NOT HAD

Four in ten children say no adult has ever discussed artificial intelligence safety with them

The phone argument is nine years old and largely settled into a stalemate. The one that matters at twelve now is a chatbot, and the numbers arrived in June.

Common Sense Media surveyed 1,204 American children aged nine to seventeen in late March, with a margin of error of 3.8 points. **Eighty-six per cent** use or interact with AI; 52 per cent weekly; 24 per cent daily. In the nine-to-twelve band, **81 per cent** use it, seventeen per cent of them every day. At thirteen to fifteen it is 89 per cent, with 28 daily.¹

What they use it for, among users: **89 per cent** for fun, **85** for schoolwork, 75 to make things. Nearly half use it for schoolwork weekly. And then the finding that should change a Sunday: **more than four in ten** say no parent or guardian has ever talked to them about AI safety, and only about a third know the thing cannot reliably tell fact from fiction.¹

1 in 6

CHATBOT USERS IN THAT SURVEY ENCOUNTERED INAPPROPRIATE MATERIAL — AND **ONLY A THIRD OF THEM TOLD A TRUSTED ADULT**. A QUARTER OF THOSE USING AI FOR EMOTIONAL SUPPORT THINK IT UNDERSTANDS THEM BETTER THAN MOST PEOPLE¹

The American Academy of Pediatrics published guidance in June that begins by refusing the easy answer: telling a family to avoid all chatbots is, in its words, **not realistic**. Its own figures put chatbot use at 67 per cent of thirteen- to seventeen-year-olds, roughly thirty per cent of them daily, and it flags the **under-fifteens** as the most vulnerable group — which is the band that matters here.²

THE CHATTER · THE SCRIPT, AND IT IS NOT AN INTERROGATION

The AAP's recommended opening is deliberately unarmed: "**How are you using AI? Can you show me how it works?**" — open, non-judgmental, and asking to be taught rather than to inspect. The rest is practical. Set privacy defaults to the most protective option. Tell her plainly that **she does not need to give a chatbot truthful or complete personal information**, which is a permission most twelve-year-olds have never been given. Fold it into a written family media plan rather than a verbal rule. And watch for the three signals that matter: changes in sleep, social withdrawal, and AI displacing responsibilities she used to meet.²

THE SCEPTIC · SPEND THE EFFORT WHERE THE LEVER IS

Two corrections to the instinctive response. **The lever is at home, not at school**. The English study on **p12** found restrictive school policies cut in-school use by 0.67 hours a day and left total weekly use unchanged — and it was total use that tracked worse mental health. A parent who lobbies the school has moved the wrong variable. **And expect the workaround, without treating it as betrayal**. Australia's regulator found 81 per cent of ten- to fifteen-year-olds still using after a national ban, mostly because platforms never checked ages; Singapore parents independently describe dummy phones.

IN BRIEF

The ten-thirty lock already exists on her school device. From January the Ministry of Education brought the default nightly lock on Personal Learning Devices forward from eleven; the setting is the school's to adjust, which makes it a question to ask rather than a rule to negotiate from scratch.³

App stores here must run age assurance from 1 April 2026 — Apple, Google, Huawei, Samsung and Microsoft — to stop under-eighteens downloading age-inappropriate apps. Both official pages render blank to this desk, so this is reported at one remove and the detail should be checked before acting on it.⁴

One in three of the children surveyed has used AI to discuss feelings or personal problems, and one in five says a month without it would be hard.¹

SOURCES 1 Common Sense Media Census: AI Use by Tweens and Teens, 2026, published 8 June 2026; the report PDF was downloaded and its methodology, age bands and figures read in the document itself — n = 1,204, fielded 18–26 March 2026, margin of error ±3.8 points on the full sample and wider on subgroups. 2 American Academy of Pediatrics, Center of Excellence on Social Media and Youth Mental Health, guidance dated 19 June 2026, read at aap.org. 3 Ministry of Education measures effective January 2026; see the sources to **p12**. 4 Infocomm Media Development Authority age-assurance requirements from 1 April 2026; imda.gov.sg renders blank to this desk and the item rests on search-result text alone — verify before relying on it. This desk found no Singapore study of AI use in this age band. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE BIG PICTURE · THE WEEK TO FRIDAY

Three central banks raised rates inside nine days, and the dollar declined to notice

The Fed hiked for the first time since 2023, the BoJ took Japan to its highest rate since 1995, and the ten-year went to 5.06 per cent. The currency that should have been the beneficiary fell.

THE LEVELS · FRIDAY 25 SEPTEMBER, CLOSE

US 10-year	5.06%	▲ 17bp wk
US 10-yr real	2.83%	▲ 21bp wk
VT (world eq.)	\$160.03	▲ 0.62%
BNDW (glob agg)	\$66.15	▲ 0.16%
DXY	100.755	▼ 0.26%
USD/JPY	157.29	▼ 0.98%
Brent	\$104.45	▼ 2.02%
Gold	\$4,273.67	▲ 0.27%
Bitcoin	\$84,111	▲ 3.3% wk

Treasury's own par curve for the 10-year; a widely-read quote page says 5.17 for the same date and the eleven-basis-point gap is not resolved here. Market explanation, not advice.¹

The chain runs from a shut strait to a mortgage rate, and this week every link in it is visible. Brent at **\$104.45** keeps headline inflation hot; American one-year inflation expectations jumped from 4.0 to **4.6 per cent** in a month; and three central banks stopped waiting.²

On 16 September the FOMC raised its target range 25 basis points to **3.75–4.00 per cent**, unanimously, twelve to nil — the first increase since 2023, on a statement that says plainly “inflation remains elevated.”³ The ECB had gone six days earlier, to a 2.50 deposit rate. The Bank of Japan followed on the 18th, to **1.25 per cent** — the highest since April 1995, and its shortest gap between hikes since 1990.⁴

5.54%

THE 20-YEAR, SITTING **ABOVE** THE 30-YEAR AT 5.49 — A FIVE-BASIS-POINT INVERSION AT THE VERY LONG END, WHICH IS WHERE DURATION INDIGESTION USUALLY SHOWS FIRST¹

The bond sleeve has returned less than nothing over a year in which world equities returned about nineteen per cent. It is not hedging. It is being paid for.

Read the curve, not the headline rate: two-year to ten-year is **+56 basis points**, and it steepened because the long end sold off, not because the front end rallied — a term-premium move, with no easing trade anywhere in it.

Gold holds the contradiction. The war bid put it there; the real-yield shock is grinding it back.⁵ Bitcoin is the cleaner liquidity read: **\$84,111**, some **33 per cent below its high**, falling while equities sit near theirs.⁶

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR WORLD EQUITIES, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BTC

One sentence each. **World equities:** earnings carry them, and a five-per-cent long bond is competition, not catastrophe. **Global bonds:** the coupon is finally real and the capital loss is still arriving — duration is the whole argument. **Gold:** two opposed forces, and the real-yield one is winning. **Singapore:** August core at 2.2 per cent is the highest since September 2024, and the policy statement lands on or before **14 October**.⁷

THE SCEPTIC · THE ANOMALY, AND A CORRECTION TO OUR OWN NUMBER

The dollar did not rally. In the week the Fed delivered its first hike in three years, with the ten-year up 17 basis points and the real ten-year up 21, DXY fell 0.26 per cent. Part is mechanical — the BoJ hiked too, so yen strength is earned. One is wrong.⁸ **Setting the record straight:** No. 114 gave Friday's ten-year as 5.10 per cent.

SOURCES 1 US Treasury daily par yield curve and daily real yield curve, September 2026, read at home.treasury.gov; 2-year 4.50, 5-year 4.81, 20-year 5.54, 30-year 5.49. 2 Brent front month and the University of Michigan September final, via the published calendar: sentiment 48.1 from 51.7, one-year expectations 4.6 from 4.0, core capital goods +1.6 against +0.3 expected. 3 FOMC statement, 16 September 2026, read in full, and the FOMC calendar; the dot-count and October probability are single-sourced. 4 The Bank of Japan's statements index confirms a “Change in the Guideline for Money Market Operations” dated 18 September; the 1.25 per cent level, the 7–2 vote and the ECB's 2.65/2.50 are single-sourced — the ECB's own statement page returned 404. Fund total returns at justETF and stockanalysis, 26 September. A quoted price for the London all-world line was labelled in the wrong currency by its source, so the verified US-listed world-equity level runs instead, and weekly changes for the London lines were unobtainable. 5 Gold spot at close, cross-checked at \$4,285 on a second page; the monthly and annual moves are single-sourced and no year-to-date figure could be verified. 6 Bitcoin spot and its drawdown from a \$126,080 high, at CoinGecko. A seven-day spot-ETF inflow of \$2.98bn circulates in that page's copy and at no primary this desk could open, so it is absent. 7 August 2026 Singapore CPI, 23 September; the MAS advance calendar puts the October statement no later than 14 October, with the Review the same day. 8 As note 2. Bureau of Economic Analysis release calendar.

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE · BEEKEEPING

The whole craft rests on a gap of nine and a half millimetres

Below six, bees glue it shut with propolis. Above nine and a half, they build comb across it. Inside the band they leave it alone — and that single tolerance, patented in 1852, is the reason a frame lifts out of a hive at all.

Before 1852 you got honey by destroying the colony. **Lorenzo Langstroth's** patent, issued on 5 October that year, did not invent a box; it identified a measurement. Bees maintain a working passage of roughly **seven millimetres, give or take two**. Give them less than six and they cement it closed. Give them more than nine and a half and they fill it with comb. Leave exactly that gap around every surface and the frames come out clean, one at a time, as many times as you like.¹

Everything downstream depends on it: inspection, disease control, queen management, the centrifugal extractor, and the migratory pollination industry that moves colonies across continents. The stack is simple once you have the gap — a **brood chamber** at the bottom where the queen lays, **supers** above it for honey, and between them a **queen excluder**, a grid sized to pass a worker and stop a queen.¹

55.6%

AMERICAN COLONY LOSSES IN 2024–25 — **THE WORST SINCE THE SURVEY BEGAN IN 2010**. MEANWHILE BERLIN'S BEEKEEPER NUMBERS MORE THAN TRIPLED BETWEEN 2005 AND 2022, WITH ZURICH, PARIS AND TORONTO ALIKE²

That pair of numbers is the honest trend line: the hobby is expanding while the animal husbandry underneath it gets harder. The scale is real. America ran **2.6 million producing colonies** in 2024 for **134 million pounds** of honey — yield **51.7 lb a colony**, price **\$2.69 a pound**, a crop worth **\$361.5m** — and spent **\$16.6m on varroa control alone**. Britain's association, founded 1874, covers 73 local groups and some **30,000 beekeepers**; Australia counts **46,000 recreational** against 1,800 commercial.³

The gateway is almost always the same fantasy, and it has a date. In February 2015 two Australians put a hive with a tap on Indiegogo, asking for A\$70,000. They raised **over twelve million dollars** and took

nearly **25,000 orders from more than 130 countries** — the largest mass conversion the hobby has ever recorded, sold on the promise of honey without opening the box.⁴

THE CHATTER · WHERE THEY GATHER, AND WHAT THEY FIGHT ABOUT

The map has three layers. **The old guard** sits on Beesource and the national association forums, where the arguments are decades old and the tone is unforgiving. **The YouTube tier** — Bob Binnie, Ian Stepler, Frederick Dunn, Kamon Reynolds, the University of Guelph's research centre — is where most newcomers actually learn, and where a commercial operator filming his own losses has more credibility than any textbook. **The institutional middle** is the Honey Bee Health Coalition, whose *Tools for Varroa Management* reached its ninth edition in June and is the document both camps argue against. It is unusually candid about its own limits: "**HBHC has not independently verified effectiveness claims made by the registrant, manufacturer, or brand.**"⁵

THE SCEPTIC · "SAVE THE BEES" IS POINTED AT THE WRONG BEE

A honeybee is livestock. Putting more hives in a city is agriculture, not conservation, and there is measurement. **Ropars and colleagues**, working in Paris, found wild-pollinator visitation falling as honeybee colony density rose — a slope of **-0.614 at 500 metres, p = 0.001**, and -0.489 at a kilometre. Paris went from about 300 colonies in 2013 to **687 by 2015**, or 6.5 per square kilometre; Brussels runs 15, London 10, against a French national average of 2.5. Their recommendation is to prioritise "floral resources and nesting habitats" over more apiaries.⁶ A 2026 framework goes further and proposes lowering hive density outright. **The honest caveat**: the competition findings are not unanimous — some studies find no direct effect — and this desk will not overclaim them. What is not in dispute is that the phrase on the tote bag describes a wild bee, and the hive on the roof contains a farmed one.

SOURCES 1 Langstroth's US Patent 9300, 5 October 1852; the tolerance band of 7 ± 2 mm and the $3/8$ -inch upper limit, with the propolis-below and comb-above mechanism quoted. It was never one number: Langstroth used about half an inch above the top bars and three-eighths between frames and body. *No hive weight is printed: the commonly repeated forty-kilo figure could not be sourced.* 2 The annual US colony-loss survey; the European urban growth figures from Casanelles-Abella et al., *People and Nature*, 2026. 3 USDA NASS Honey, 14 March 2025, read from the PDF; the British and Australian associations' own sites, the latter undated on the page. A claimed US beekeeper count of 120,000 comes only from vendor marketing and is not printed. 4 The Flow Hive Indiegogo campaign, February 2015. 5 Honey Bee Health Coalition, *Tools for Varroa Management*, ninth edition, 11 June 2026. 6 Ropars, Dajoz, Fontaine, Muratet and Geslin, *PLOS ONE*, 2019. **No Reddit or Beesource material appears anywhere in this desk**: Reddit refused every route including four mirrors, and Beesource sits behind a payment-required bot wall.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR, AND THE ARGUMENT

A set of spare frames costs more than a complete extractor

The hobby's most famous product sells the one thing the craft cannot be done without: opening the box. Here is what it costs, what the community actually says, and why none of it works in Singapore.

The **Flow Hive** is where most outsiders meet this hobby, so start with its price list. A Flow Hive 2+ in western red cedar is **US\$899** with a stand, \$1,059 at seven frames. A spare set of Flow Frames alone runs **\$259 to \$449** — and a Dadant two-frame hand extractor, which harvests any hive ever built, is **\$309.95**. The frames cost more than the machine they exist to replace.¹

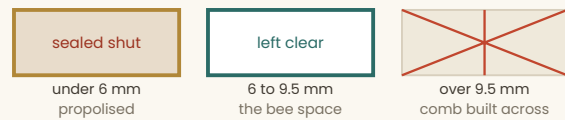
The documented criticism is not snobbery. The product was marketed as harvesting “without disturbing the bees,” and, as Wikipedia records it, “many experienced beekeepers said that this misrepresented the importance of hive maintenance” — after which its inventor reframed the claim to say it “only changes the honey harvesting process.” On the company's own forum, **JeffH** logged the practical failure in 2016: “There's been lots of issues with leaking honey into & out through the brood box & onto the ground.” A poster on the same thread made the husbandry objection — never entering the hive is “counter productive to bee health” — and the ripeness one: honey above twenty per cent moisture “is considered unripe and may ferment.”²

\$40

AN ANALOGUE REFRACTOMETER, THE INSTRUMENT THAT TELLS YOU WHETHER THE HONEY IS UNDER THAT MOISTURE LINE. THE DIGITAL ONE IS **\$328** AND TELLS YOU THE SAME THING.³

The buy-once build, at read prices. A cotton suit is \$49.95 and a **ventilated three-layer Ultra Breeze jumpsuit \$289** — in this climate that is not a luxury, it is the difference between an inspection and a sauna. A tin smoker is \$36.95; a stainless Dadant with a heat shield and finger guard **\$59.95**. Hive tool \$13.50, J-hook \$12.95, frame grip \$26.50, brush \$8.95. A nucleus colony is **\$109**, a package \$89. Extraction is where the money goes: hand crank **\$309.95**, powered radial **\$995.95**, twenty-frame **\$1,895.95**.³

THE GAP, AND WHAT THEY DO WITH IT



Langstroth's patent, 5 October 1852.

THE SCEPTIC · THREE DIFFERENT NUMBERS FROM ONE COMPANY

Beewise builds a robotic hive with computer vision and a heat chamber, raised **\$50m in a Series D** in June 2025 on nearly \$170m total, and has **1,240 units** deployed across 300,000 acres. Its website claims “**70% lower bee colony loss**”; its chief executive's public figures — eight per cent annual collapse against an industry baseline above forty — imply about **80**; he has separately said the reduction is **80 per cent**. Three reductions, one company, one year. Reporting on the firm notes there are **no peer-reviewed studies, no third-party audits and no independent verification**; the inspectors' association supplied the industry baseline but did not check Beewise's own numbers, and the only outside voice is a customer. The company is about a year from profitability and declined to disclose its valuation.⁴ **What would settle it:** one independent season-long comparison.

THE CUTTING EDGE

VarroxDan — extended-release oxalic acid strips, registered 1 December 2023 — is the genuine step. One strip per two and a half frames, in the hive 42 to 56 days. Trial efficacy **95.3 per cent in Uruguay, 97.7 in Argentina, 95.4 in Greece**; at Washington State, final infestation **0.24 per cent against 5.58** for the incumbent. The breakthrough is the label, not the kill rate: **no temperature restriction, and approved with honey supers in place** — a mite treatment you can run during the flow.⁴

The coalition that publishes the thresholds will not vouch for it. Its ninth edition reports the brand's claimed 92 to 98 per cent and then states plainly that it “has not independently verified effectiveness claims made by the registrant, manufacturer, or brand.”⁴

SOURCES 1 honeyflow.com product feed, read 26 September 2026; every Flow Hive 2+ variant showed sold out with mid-October dispatch that day. 2 Wikipedia's documented criticism of the product and Cedar Anderson's reframing; the forum posts are from Flow's own hosted forum, dated 4 September 2016 onward. A competitor's blog compiling five further complaints was read and is **not** used as evidence here, because it is marketing and its quotations come from a platform this desk cannot verify. 3 Dealer price pages for smokers, suits, tools, refractometers and extractors, read 26 September 2026; the Ultra Breeze price is the maker's own. Michael Bush at bushfarms.com and Randy Oliver at scientificbeekeeping.com, both read in full. Vita Bee Health's own efficacy-trials summary, authored by its technical director, plus the Honey Bee Health Coalition's ninth-edition entry — which reports the brand's claimed 92 to 98 per cent while stating it has not independently verified it. The retail price could not be read: the listed stockist refuses bots. 4 Beewise's Series D announcement of 9 June 2025, the company's own site, and independent reporting of June 2025 that records the absence of verification and the undisclosed valuation.

THE DEEP END · THE EQUATOR, AND THE MONEY

Everything in the manuals assumes a winter. Singapore does not have one

No winter means no brood break, which means no pause in the mite's breeding cycle and no window for half the treatments. And the local bee's answer to a bad month is not to cluster and wait. It is to leave.

The Western literature is built on an overwintering animal: you build a colony toward a spring flow, treat in the autumn gap when brood-rearing pauses, and count your losses after the cluster. **None of that exists at the equator.** There is year-round brood and therefore year-round mites; there is no single flow to super for, only a rolling tree-by-tree nectar supply; and **absconding, not winter loss, is the tropical failure mode.**¹

The bee is different too. *Apis cerana*, the Asian hive bee, runs colonies of about **six to seven thousand workers** against the European bee's fifty thousand-plus, absconds far more readily — and, having coevolved with its mite, grooms effectively against it. The European bee in the tropics has neither that resistance nor a brood break. That is the technical reason a Langstroth-and-*mellifera* setup is a harder proposition here than in Surrey.¹

133

BEE SPECIES IN SINGAPORE ON THE FIRST COMPREHENSIVE NATIONAL CHECKLIST — 106 NAMED PLUS 27 MORPHOSPECIES — OF WHICH **SEVEN ARE STINGLESS** AND OVER A HUNDRED SOLITARY. FOUR ARE HONEY BEES²

Which points at the realistic local route, and it is not a Langstroth on a balcony. It is **stingless bees** — meliponines, which have no sting at all. **Nutrinest**, run by Xavier Tan since 2014, rehomes rescued colonies into four gardens at Sembawang, Orchard Road, Jurong Town Hall and Mandai, and reports **over five thousand visitors with zero stings recorded.** Its course ladder runs from a beginners' class through practical handling to queen rearing and the optional adoption of a colony, taught on *Apis*

cerana and local dwarf and stingless species. Prices are by enquiry only.³

THE CHATTER · ON WHETHER IT IS EVEN LEGAL HERE, NOBODY WILL SAY

This is the finding, not a gap in the reporting. The national wildlife authority's public page on bees contains **no beekeeping regulation whatever** — it is a safety page telling you to back away and call a helpline. No permit information, no statement that keeping bees is or is not allowed. **On the condominium balcony specifically, there is no official answer at all**, and the binding constraint is not national law but the management corporation's by-laws and one neighbour's nuisance complaint.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE SPREADSHEET, HONESTLY

One hive, year one: bees \$125–200, boxes \$150–250, tools and protection \$75–200, training up to \$100 — call it **\$350 to \$800**, and roughly **\$700 to \$1,600 for two**, which is the number that matters because you should start with two. The trade's own writers say it plainly — “Beekeeping isn't a cheap hobby” and “there is no guarantee of profit.”⁵ And the thing the money cannot buy is the attrition: more than half of American colonies died last year.

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Letterpress printing — polymer against lead type, and a press you cannot move alone.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and a cave in a wine fridge.

Bookbinding & book repair — Coptic to case binding, and the archival-materials rabbit hole.

SOURCES 1 Species comparison and absconding behaviour per the reference literature on *Apis cerana*, including its coevolved grooming defence against *Varroa jacobsoni*; the consequences for brood breaks, flows and treatment windows are this desk's reasoning from those facts, not a quoted claim. 2 The national wildlife authority's own figure of over 130 documented species, and Soh and Ascher's checklist — the first comprehensive country checklist and conservation assessment for a Southeast Asian bee fauna — giving 133 species, 106 named plus 27 morphospecies, with seven extant stingless species. 3 Nutrinest's own site and course pages, read 26 September 2026; course prices are not published. A correction to a claim circulating elsewhere: the BEE Amazed Garden is not in Sengkang — it was founded in Yishun in December 2017 and moved to a university rooftop in 2022. 4 The authority's bees-and-wasps page, which carries no regulation; the operator's quoted refusal; the remaining positions are unofficial and flagged as such. 5 Cost itemisation and the two quotations from a long-running beekeeping educator's cost breakdown; yields and prices from USDA NASS 2024 as cited on p15. The one rigorous academic break-even costing this desk found returned 403, so its numbers are absent.

THE LONG GAME · THE NUMBER THAT MOVED

Stop asking what your VO2 max is. Ask which way it is going

Eleven and a half thousand people, two fitness tests four years apart, fourteen years of follow-up. The finding is not the level — it is the annual slope, and there is no threshold at which improving stops paying.

López-Bueno and colleagues took 11,530 UK Biobank participants aged forty to seventy-three, each of whom had done a submaximal cycle test twice, about four years apart, and followed them for a median of **fourteen years**. The exposure was not fitness. It was the change in fitness, annualised.¹

Per one additional millilitre per kilogramme per minute per year of improvement: incident cardiovascular disease **hazard ratio 0.85** (95% CI 0.75–0.96), and cardiovascular mortality **0.66** (0.51–0.87). Declines ran the other way. The dose–response was approximately linear across the whole range, **with no threshold effect** — no point at which getting fitter stopped counting.¹

0.66

HAZARD RATIO FOR CARDIOVASCULAR DEATH, PER +1 ML/KG/MIN PER YEAR — ADJUSTED FOR BASELINE FITNESS, SO THE BENEFIT IS FROM CHANGING, NOT FROM WHERE YOU STARTED¹

That baseline adjustment is the part worth holding onto. The model also controls for genetic predisposition, BMI change and physical activity. What it is measuring is the trajectory itself.

THE CHATTER · THE LONGEVITY CROWD IS ARGUING ABOUT WHO QUIT WHAT

The rapamycin argument has turned, and it turned on its own advocates. **Bryan Johnson removed it from his protocol in March** after roughly five years as its most public user, citing intermittent skin and soft-tissue infections, dyslipidemia, raised glucose and a rising resting heart rate — plus a preprint claiming the drug accelerates ageing signals across sixteen epigenetic clocks. **Peter Attia** stopped his own in 2025 over recurring mouth ulcers, a known effect, while still prescribing it to under a tenth of his patients. **David Sinclair** is reported still taking it weekly. The disagreement underneath is epistemological: Sinclair weights animal lifespan data, Johnson weights his own biomarker panel. The fair rebuttal from the pro-rapamycin side is that Johnson runs fifty-plus compounds at once, so attribution is hopeless. *The Attia and Sinclair positions here are reported by commercial longevity sites rather than by the men themselves — treat them as secondary.*²

THE SCEPTIC · NAMED, PEER-REVIEWED, AND UNIMPRESSED

Roark and Iffland, in *Frontiers in Aging*, catalogue what chronic mTOR inhibition actually does: mucosal ulcers, impaired wound healing, raised infection risk, elevated cholesterol and triglycerides, glucose intolerance. They note the **PEARL trial** found low-dose intermittent rapamycin well tolerated over a year but producing only “modest changes in biomarkers” of biological ageing, and that a systematic review found gains in immune, cardiovascular and skin systems but **not** endocrine, muscular or neurological. Their warning about cancer is the one people skip: autophagy may suppress tumour *initiation* while supporting the survival of *established* tumours. Their bottom line: “until long-term data are available, caution is warranted — particularly when considering the use of rapamycin in otherwise healthy individuals.”³ The editorial accompanying this week’s lead study makes a quieter but equally sharp point: it does not tell you how much training buys one millilitre a year.⁴

SOURCES 1 López-Bueno et al., “Longitudinal changes of cardiorespiratory fitness are associated with cardiovascular disease and mortality: evidence from the UK Biobank,” *European Journal of Preventive Cardiology*, 17 August 2026, doi 10.1093/eurjpc/zwag383. Limitations this desk adds, since the abstract does not enumerate them: VO2 max was *estimated* from a submaximal cycle test, not measured; the study is observational, so reverse causation from early subclinical disease cannot be excluded; two measurements define the trajectory; and UK Biobank volunteers are healthier than the population. 2 Johnson’s withdrawal is corroborated across three independent write-ups; the Attia and Sinclair positions come from commercial longevity sites, not their own channels, and are flagged as secondary. No forum sentiment appears here: Reddit refused every route tried. 3 Roark and Iffland, “Rapamycin for longevity: the pros, the cons, and future perspectives,” *Frontiers in Aging*, 20 June 2025. 4 Cadore and Pietta-Dias, editorial, *EJPC*, 10 July 2026. 5 Dial et al., *Physiological Reports*, 20 August 2025 — thirteen participants, 536 nights, against a chest-strap ECG. General guidance, not medical advice.

DEPARTURES · THE WEEK'S CHANGES

Book by Tuesday, or pay the levy on every ticket you buy afterwards

The airline's winter schedule is its biggest since 2020 — and South Asia and Bali are where it took the capacity from. Meanwhile a ticketing deadline three days away decides what your next long-haul fare costs.

The deadline first, because it is three days out. Singapore's sustainable-fuel levy applies to **tickets sold from 1 October**, for departures from Singapore from 1 January. Not to inbound journeys, not to transits — only to tickets issued from Wednesday. Per passenger: **S\$1 economy and S\$4 business to Southeast Asia; S\$2.80 and S\$11.20 to Northeast and South Asia and Australia; S\$6.40 and S\$25.60 to Europe, the Middle East and New Zealand; S\$10.40 and S\$41.60 to the Americas.**¹

Worked through, a business saver to London goes from **S\$65.20 of tax to S\$90.80** — up 39 per cent. The catch that will bite people: a waitlisted award that clears after Tuesday, or a held fare paid for on Wednesday, attracts it. The ticket must be issued by **30 September.**¹

2,530

WEEKLY FLIGHTS BY MARCH — SINGAPORE AIRLINES' LARGEST SCHEDULE SINCE APRIL 2020, ABOUT 92 PER CENT OF ITS JANUARY 2020 NETWORK²

Where the aircraft went, and where they came from. Announced on Sunday: **Madrid via Barcelona, five weekly from 26 October** — the first Madrid service in twenty-two years. Western Sydney's new airport gets a daily A350 from 23 November; Riyadh three weekly from 1 December; Dubai returns daily on 25 October *and loses First Class*, because it comes back on an A350 rather than an A380. Gatwick doubles to twice daily, Adelaide and Christchurch both hit record frequencies.²

The cuts are the story for anyone flying west or south. **Colombo halves, fourteen weekly to seven. Johannesburg halves. Bali loses about a fifth of its capacity.** Europe and Australasia got the winter

aircraft; South Asia paid for them — which is the context for the Grand Tour on **p21.**²

THE CHATTER · MORE FLIGHTS, FEWER GOOD SEATS

Ho Chi Minh City goes from twenty-one weekly to **twenty-eight** on 25 October, which reads as expansion until you check the metal: a 787-10 rotation drops to a 737-8, so weekly seats actually fall **6,489 to 6,286** and **business seats fall 798 to 686 — down 14 per cent.** Da Nang is the genuine gain, two daily to three, up fifty per cent on seats. And the cabin everyone is waiting for is **not** flying yet: the new long-haul business seat enters service from the first quarter of 2027 and the new First Class mid-to-late 2027. Anyone told they are booking the new product this winter is being told a story.³

IN BRIEF

Air Canada ends Singapore-Vancouver on 26 January after under three years, with no airline statement — leaving **no non-stop service between Singapore and Canada at all.**⁴

EgyptAir returns in early 2027 with Cairo-Singapore-Sydney on an A350: thirty flat beds and 310 economy. It last flew the route to 2002, and the fifth-freedom selling rights on the Sydney leg are unresolved.⁵

A correction worth carrying: Jetstar Asia does not exist. It ceased all operations on **31 July 2025**, seven weeks after the announcement, with sixteen routes and thirteen aircraft. Do not plan around a 3K flight.⁶

Japan's tax-free shopping changes on 1 November: you will pay the tax-inclusive price in the shop and **claim the refund at the airport** before check-in. The ¥5,000 threshold is unchanged, but the general-goods versus consumables split is abolished along with the sealed-packaging rule, and the purchase window is unified at **90 days.**⁷

ETIAS will not start this year. The European Commission still says "last quarter of 2026" — but also that it will announce the date **at least six months beforehand**, which as of today makes a 2026 start arithmetically impossible. The entry-exit system, by contrast, has been fully operational across Schengen since **10 April.**⁸

SOURCES 1 Levy bands and the ticketing cutoff per the civil aviation authority as reported 21 September 2026, with the worked London example. 2 Singapore Airlines' northern-winter schedule announcement of 20 September 2026. 3 Route and aircraft changes of 16 September; the business-cabin and First Class rollout dates from the carrier's own product-by-route listings of 23 and 25 September. Retrofit aircraft counts are unpublished. 4 Announced 22 September 2026. 5 Announced 12 September 2026; frequency unannounced and subject to regulatory approval. 6 Closure announced 11 June 2025, operations ended 31 July 2025. 7 Japan's tax-free reform effective 1 November 2026. 8 European Commission page dated 28 April 2026; the ETIAS fee is not stated on it and is not printed here. **Held and not printed:** the Johor Bahru-Singapore rail link, whose fare and start date both ministers have said will be announced jointly and neither has — the target has drifted from end-2026 to around January 2027, and the circulating S\$5-7 fare is unofficial. Changi Terminal 5 remains a mid-2030s project with no September milestone. No Japan Rail Pass change was found this week.

DEPARTURES · RAIL, ROOMS AND POINTS

Two passes became one, and under-twelves now travel Europe free

The quieter half of the week's changes: a rail-pass merger that removes a distinction nobody could explain, a new sleeper across the Alps, and a ski hotel with a gondola arriving three months after it.

On 9 September Eurail and Interrail merged into a single Interrail brand, ending a split that existed only to separate European residents from everyone else. Two consequences matter more than the branding: **Ouigo now accepts the pass**, and **under-twelves travel free** with an adult holding a Youth or Senior pass.¹

The day after, **European Sleeper opened Brussels–Milan**, three times a week, with daytime Eurostar connections from London – a night train across the Alps that did not exist a month ago. Ahead of it: a Hamburg–Munich sleeper with flat-bed “Nox Suites” from **€65** in March 2027, and Brussels and Amsterdam to Copenhagen and Malmö planned for 2028.¹

310

ROOMS AT MOXY NISEKO VILLAGE, OPENED THIS MONTH – SKI-IN, SKI-OUT AT THE GONDOLA BASE, WITH A **NEW EIGHT-PERSON GONDOLA IN DECEMBER** DOUBLING UPLIFT AND OPENING THIRTY KILOMETRES OF TERRAIN²

It is the brand's first Japanese alpine hotel: an outdoor foot onsen, a bar that doubles as the check-in desk, two hours from New Chitose and ten minutes from the JR station. No rates have been published, which for a first season at Niseko is itself a signal.²

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE MILES ARE CHEAP THIS MONTH

October's KrisFlyer promotion is **30 per cent off saver awards** in three cabins, booked 15–30 September for travel in October. Business: **Bali 15,400, Bangkok 17,500, Beijing and Shanghai 31,500, Cairns 50,400**. Economy: Bali 5,600, Bangkok 9,100, Hong Kong and Taipei 10,850, Sydney 20,300. **Colombo is in it both ways – 13,300 in economy, 25,200 in premium**, which is the cheapest way into the Grand Tour on **p21**, if you can travel next month. All of it is non-refundable and non-changeable. Scoot's parallel offer is 15 per cent, same window.³

THE SCEPTIC · THREE THINGS THIS DESK WILL NOT TELL YOU THIS WEEK

The Johor rail link has no date and no fare. As of mid-August the Malaysian transport minister said both would be announced jointly by the two ministers, and neither has been; the target has slipped from end-2026 toward January 2027, and the S\$5–7 figure circulating is unofficial. Four kilometres, five minutes, immigration cleared once at the departure station – all true, and none of it bookable. **Thailand's arrival card and Bali's levy produced no verifiable change** this week; every official page this desk tried rendered empty or refused. **And the Japan Rail Pass has not moved** since the rise already covered – the official domain does not resolve from here, and printing a price this desk could not read would be worse than printing nothing.

LOUNGES AND ENTRY RULES

Two new lounges at Bangkok Suvarnabhumi, opened late August in Concourse G: a **578-square-metre, 98-seat** lounge open around the clock, walk-in **THB 1,750** for two hours, now taking Priority Pass and DragonPass; and a **212-square-metre First** next door at THB 2,400. *Nothing was found at Changi in the window; its newsroom refuses extraction.*⁴

Japan's departure tax tripled to ¥3,000 on 1 July, collected inside the ticket price, for every departing passenger regardless of nationality or cabin – exempting under-twos and transits under 24 hours that do not clear immigration.⁵

Japan's pre-travel authorisation is now law – passed 29 May, promulgated 5 June as Act No. 32 of 2026 – but starts by government ordinance **no later than 31 March 2029**, on an operational target of financial year 2028. It will apply to visa-exempt visitors, so Singapore passports, one authorisation per entry. The fee is not set.⁶

Sri Lanka's tourist ETA is free for Singaporeans from 25 May – thirty days, double entry, no fee. See **p22**.⁷

SOURCES 1 Seat61's rail news page, read 26 September 2026, for the 9 September merger, the Ouigo and under-twelve changes, the 10 September Brussels–Milan launch and the forward services. 2 Moxxy Niseko Village opening release, 4 September 2026; no rates published. 3 KrisFlyer and Scoot Spontaneous Escapes for October 2026, booking window 15–30 September. No award-chart devaluation appeared this week; the last structural change was November 2025 and is treated as background. 4 Plaza Premium's two Suvarnabhumi lounges, opened 28 August 2026, reported 13 September. 5 Japan's departure tax from 1 July 2026, per a secondary account citing the transport ministry and flagged as secondary. 6 The legislative account of the authorisation bill, preferred here over an encyclopaedia entry that is stale on both the date and the act number. 7 Sri Lanka's Department of Immigration and Emigration ETA portal, read at source.

THE GRAND TOUR · SRI LANKA'S HILL COUNTRY

The most photographed train in Asia has not run to Kandy since November

A cyclone split the line near Balana and obliterated six sections of track. Colombo services still terminate an hour out of the city. The half that reopened is the half everyone who has ridden it says was better anyway.

On 27 November 2025 Cyclone Ditwah put 159 landslides and 95 washouts into Sri Lanka's railway. On the Colombo–Badulla main line the damage came to **Rs 69 billion at 223 locations**, and at Balana the line was physically split: **six track sections completely obliterated**, three tunnels blocked, and the support pillar of the Black Bridge left tilted. An engineer measured it: “The pillar tilted about 7–8 degrees in the opposite direction of the water flow.”¹

The April restoration deadline was missed. The revised target is **31 December 2026**. As of the latest account, a railway spokesman puts it plainly: “**Currently, on the upcountry line, trains travel from Colombo only up to Rambukkana**” — about an hour out, nowhere near Kandy.¹

1,898 m

PATTIPOLA, THE SUMMIT STATION AND THE HIGHEST BROAD-GAUGE STATION IN THE COUNTRY. THE LINE TOOK SIXTY YEARS TO CLIMB HERE: KANDY 1867, NANU OYA 1885, BANDARAWELA 1894, BADULLA 1924²

What is open is the eastern half. Ambewela to Badulla via Ella came back around 1 January; **Nanu Oya to Badulla resumed on 20 June**. Rambukkana to Nanu Oya is still under repair. So the journey is available only as **Nanu Oya – Ella – Badulla**, reached by road — and here is the accident: that is the good half.³

Seat61 names **Hatton–Nanu Oya–Ella** as the scenic core. A trip report that has ridden the whole thing is blunter — skip the classic route, take Ella–Badulla, one hour each way, still crossing the Nine Arch Bridge: “The train carriage was **completely empty** when I got on at Ella.” And the Kandy–Nuwara Eliya leg that is currently shut is one-sided: the right gives

tea and open views, the left gives “tall grass and a cliff.”⁴

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRIP REPORTS SAY AGAINST THE PHOTOGRAPH

“**First class**” is three different products and two are **sealed boxes**. The air-conditioned car's windows are “small and slightly grubby”; a reviewer is blunter — “the windows and doors are kept shut so you can't take photos.” The observation saloon is better but has only two pairs of seats with an uninterrupted rear view. Seat61's counter-intuitive advice stands: **third class reserved beats second class unreserved** — a guaranteed seat in an empty car against standing in a full one. Delays are structural, not occasional: “a minimum of one hour on each leg,” with the full run taking nine or ten hours against a timetabled six to eight, and boarding “a bit of a ‘free for all.’” Reservations open **30 days** ahead; the official site will not sell inside **96 hours**, which leaves a dead zone where you must queue at a counter.⁵

THE SCEPTIC · THE PHOTOGRAPH HAS KILLED SOMEONE

The image that sells this journey — a body leaning out of an open doorway over a green valley — is not a spontaneous moment. One rider's account: it “is a result of **waiting for your turn for quite a while**,” and another describes six locals crowding into the same doorway at once. It is also genuinely dangerous. In February 2025 a **53-year-old Russian tourist died** after hanging from the footboard of the Badulla–Colombo service to take a photograph, striking a rock near a dam between Badulla and Hali Ela; a separate report records a tourist critically injured doing the same thing. The reason is geometric: “The train does come scarily close to the cliffs and tunnel walls.”⁶ **The honest verdict from the people who have ridden it:** the views are real and you cannot see that country from a road; the *experience* is not what the photographs suggest. Nobody says don't go.

SOURCES 1 Sri Lanka Railways' own disaster-recovery bulletin for the national damage figures, and *The Morning*, 19 April 2026, for the Rs 69 billion, the 223 locations, the six obliterated sections at Balana, the tilted pillar and the quoted spokesman. 2 Reference material on the Main Line: 290 km, 5 ft 6 in broad gauge, 43 numbered tunnels, and the section-by-section opening dates. 3 Reopening dates per Sri Lanka Railways and contemporaneous local reporting of 18 June 2026; Seat61 carries a standing warning that Colombo–Kandy and the tea-country route remain affected. 4 Seat61's Sri Lanka page, read in full, plus two dated trip reports. 5 Fares, classes, the 30-day reservation window and the 96-hour online cutoff were read at Seat61 and confirmed on the railway's own booking portal; the delay and boarding accounts are from the trip reports, attributed as such. **TripAdvisor refused every fetch and Reddit is closed to this desk**, so the community voice here is dated trip reports rather than forum threads — a weaker substitute, and named as one. 6 The death was reported in the Sri Lankan press in February 2025 and picked up internationally; that outlet refuses direct fetches, so the account here rests on the corroborating international report and the search record, and the victim's name is deliberately not printed because this desk could not verify its spelling at source. **Also held:** the private carriage operators named in older guides — two of their domains no longer resolve, and Seat61 does not cover them, so none is listed as bookable.

THE GRAND TOUR · THE ESTATES, AND THE MONTH

The grades are a sieve setting, and December is not the dry season

Two monsoons split these hills down the middle, so Ella and Nuwara Eliya have opposite weather. February and March are the window — and the letters on the tea caddy describe leaf size, not quality.

Sri Lanka has **two monsoons**, and the hill country sits on the watershed between them. The southwest monsoon, roughly May to September, hits the western slopes — Nuwara Eliya, Hatton, Dimbula, Adam’s Peak. The northeast monsoon, October to January, hits the eastern flank — **Uva: Ella, Bandarawela, Haputale**. There is no single dry season for “the hills,” because the hills are two places.¹

Which makes the guidebook advice wrong in a specific way. Nuwara Eliya in **December takes 182.9 mm over 14.9 wet days**; in **February, 72.7 mm over 6.7**. Kandy: 196 mm and 14 days in December against 74 mm and five in February. **February and March are the hill country’s real window**, and October and November are its worst — Nuwara Eliya 246.6 mm then 226.4. And because Ella is on the Uva flank, it is *wettest* precisely when the guides send you there.¹

–2.6°C

NUWARA ELIYA’S RECORD LOW, IN JANUARY, AT 1,868 METRES. THE MEAN JANUARY MINIMUM IS **10.4°C** AND MANY HILL HOTELS HAVE NO HEATING. PACK A REAL JACKET, AND ONE FOR THE TWELVE-YEAR-OLD¹

Now the estates, which nobody explains. Ceylon tea is graded by elevation because altitude changes the leaf: cooler air, slower growth, a smaller and slower-flushing leaf, and a lighter, brighter, more aromatic cup. Low country grows faster, with more biomass and more astringency — which is why low-grown Ceylon is the Middle East’s preference, not a lesser product. It is also the majority: **79,836 hectares low against 52,272 high**.²

The tea board’s own districts read as a tasting map: **Nuwara Eliya** the palest with a golden hue, **Dimbula** fine golden-orange, **Uva** “exotically aromatic,” **Uda Pussellawa** darker with a pinkish cast, **Kandy** bright

and coppery. And the thing the caddy will not tell you: **BOP, BOPF, OP, Pekoe, Dust are LEAF-SIZE grades, sorted by mesh screen** — eight to thirty. A broken-orange-pekoie fanning is a smaller particle, not a worse tea. Anyone selling you “OP equals premium” is selling you a sieve setting.²

THE HONEST LAYER · WHO ACTUALLY PICKS IT

The estates were built on labour recruited from southern India from **1827**, and the Ceylon Citizenship Act of 1948 left **more than 600,000 Indian Tamils stateless** — a status most did not shed until the 1980s and 90s, with the final grants in **2003**. They remain, in the standard description, among the poorest and most neglected groups in the country, housed in “line rooms.” In Nuwara Eliya district they are the largest community, **355,830 people, 50.57 per cent**. The daily wage rose from Rs 1,350 to **Rs 1,750 from 1 January**, signed at the end of that month — and the structure is where it turns: only **Rs 200 of the Rs 400 rise falls on the employers**, the other Rs 200 being a government attendance allowance paid into workers’ accounts. Whether the new figure is reaching people in full, this desk could not establish.³

THE PRACTICALITIES · AND THREE THINGS THE GUIDES GET WRONG

Getting there: Singapore Airlines **halves Colombo to seven weekly from 25 October (p19)**; SriLankan flies it in about **3h50m**; Scoot does not. Total non-stop capacity is falling. **The visa is now free** for Singaporeans — thirty days, double entry, since 25 May. **The expressway is not the answer yet:** only the 41 km Mirigama–Kurunegala section is open, the Kandy link is not due before 2028, so budget a normal road transfer. On money: the rupee has weakened about twelve per cent against the dollar since Seat61 last updated its conversions, so **anything priced in rupees is soft and anything priced in dollars has been re-based** — which is the honest post-crisis split.⁴

SOURCES 1 Monsoon geography and the station climate tables for Nuwara Eliya (1,868 m), Kandy (500 m), Haputale (1,431 m) and Ella (1,041 m). One inference is flagged: no per-station table for Ella, Bandarawela or Ohiya could be obtained — the climate host refused throughout — so the statement that Ella is wetter than Nuwara Eliya in December is reasoned from the monsoon geography and the tea board’s own account of Uva’s seasonality, not measured. 2 The Sri Lanka Tea Board’s own district descriptions, and reference material on Ceylon tea production for the hectareage and the mesh-screen grading. The ~1,200 m high-grown boundary is industry standard but this desk could not read it on an official page, so it is described rather than cited. 3 The plantation workers’ history and the 2024 population figure; the wage rise signed 30 January 2026 and its Rs 1,550-plus-Rs 200 structure, with the quoted critique from a Sri Lankan policy analysis of November 2025. Whether Rs 1,750 is reaching workers in full is not established by any source read. 4 The airline’s winter schedule; the immigration department’s own ETA portal; the expressway’s stage-by-stage status; the national park’s published fees and the early-morning cloud advisory; the pilgrimage season and the lit trail.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

One ballot has already closed, one show sold out in four nights, and one Christmas has not been announced at all

Every row below was re-checked against a promoter, a venue or an official ticketing page this weekend. Three things previous issues listed are not happening in the form they were listed.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 2-4 OCT

★ **Octoburst! — A Children's Festival**

ESPLANADE · **ALL TWELVE EVENTS FREE**, BILLED FOR "ALL AGES AND ABILITIES". THE BEST-VALUE FAMILY DATE IN THE WINDOW¹
- 9-11 OCT

★ **Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix — the sprint weekend**

MARINA BAY · SPRINT QUALIFYING FRIDAY, SPRINT AND QUALIFYING SATURDAY, RACE SUNDAY NOON · **HIGHEST SELL-OUT RISK ON THIS PAGE**²
- 15-18 OCT

da:ns focus — Cloud Gate Dance Theatre of Taiwan

ESPLANADE · **\$27.20–\$42.50**; MASTERCLASSES \$40–\$60, TALKS FREE¹
- 21 OCT

Junior and the Holiday Magic — SRT's The Little Company

DRAMA CENTRE · **\$22–\$52**, 15% OFF A FAMILY PACKAGE OF FOUR · RECOMMENDED FOUR AND UP; CLOSING DATE UNPUBLISHED³
- 13-22 NOV

★ **Singapore Writers Festival — "Hidden in Plain Sight"**

MULTIPLE VENUES · FESTIVAL PASS **\$30**, **YOUTH PASS \$15** — OVER A HUNDRED PROGRAMMES ON THE PASS⁴
- 25 NOV

Guns N' Roses — World Tour 2026

NATIONAL STADIUM, 8PM · **STILL ON SALE**, THREE VIP TIERS; PRICE BANDS UNPUBLISHED⁵
- 17-22 DEC

★ **BTS — World Tour 'ARIRANG'**

NATIONAL STADIUM, FOUR NIGHTS (17, 19, 20, 22), 7PM · **SOLD OUT** ON BOTH THE GENERAL AND PARTNER SALES; FACE VALUE WAS \$148–\$388. RESALE ONLY⁶
- 22-24 JAN

ART SG 2027 — fifth edition

MARINA BAY SANDS · VERNISSAGE 21 JAN · PUBLIC TICKETING NOT YET POSTED⁷
- 16 FEB-4 APR

Moulin Rouge! The Musical

SANDS THEATRE · THE 4 APRIL CLOSING DATE IS FROM TRADE PRESS, NOT THE VENUE, WHOSE SITE REFUSES THIS DESK⁸

JAPAN & THE REGION

THE ONES WITH A TICKET CLOCK

- 10-24 JAN

★ **Hatsu Basho — the January grand sumo tournament**

RYÖGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE TICKETS GO ON SALE SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER**; THE BANZUKE IS PUBLISHED 21 DEC.
- 8-22 NOV

Kyushu Basho — Fukuoka

FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · TICKETS OPENED 19 SEP AND THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN SITE NOW READS **SOLD OUT, ALL DATES**⁹
- 9 SEP-13 DEC

Masterpieces of the Renaissance from the Louvre

THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · TIMED ENTRY LIKELY; PRICES NOT ON THE ENGLISH INDEX¹⁰
- 30 OCT-11 JAN

★ **Haikyu!! Exhibition — CHALLENGERS**

MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, ROPPONGI HILLS · ANIME SHOWS HERE ARE TIMED-ENTRY AND GO ON WEEKENDS — THE STRONGEST TWELVE-YEAR-OLD PICK IN TOKYO¹¹
- 28 OCT-8 FEB

Shojo Manga Infinity — Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato

THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · THREE OF THE FORM'S FOUNDING ARTISTS IN ONE ROOM¹⁰
- 11-13 DEC

Tokyo Comic Con — tenth anniversary

MAKUHARI MESSE · **PHOTO AND SIGNING SESSIONS ARE PRICED SEPARATELY AND SELL OUT**¹²
- 4-11 FEB

★ **Sapporo Snow Festival**

ODORI PARK, SUSUKINO AND TSUDOME · THE CONSTRAINT IS NOT TICKETS, IT IS BEDS: **BOOK SAPPORO SIX TO NINE MONTHS OUT**. TSUDOME HAS THE GIANT SLIDE¹³
- 7 MAR

Tokyo Marathon — twentieth edition

THE BALLOT HAS CLOSED. GENERAL ENTRY RAN 14-28 AUG AND RESULTS WENT OUT ON 18 SEP; CHARITY CLOSED 31 AUG.
- 17-31 JAN

Australian Open 2027 — Melbourne

OPENING WEEK 11-16 JAN, MAIN DRAW FROM THE 17TH, FINALS 30-31 · TRAVEL PACKAGES ON SALE; **GENERAL TICKET RELEASE STILL TO BE ANNOUNCED**¹⁵
- 25-27 MAR

Art Basel Hong Kong 2027

HKCEC, WAN CHAI · TICKETING NOT YET OPEN¹⁴ · PAIRS WITH ART SG IN JANUARY FOR AN ART-CALENDAR SPREAD¹⁶

SOURCES 1 Esplanade's own festival pages for Octoburst!, da:ns focus and Kalaa Utsavam 2026. 2 formula1.com's 2026 Singapore session schedule and singaporegp.sg. 3 Singapore Repertory Theatre. 4 singaporewritersfestival.com. 5 Live Nation Singapore event page. 6 Live Nation Singapore, which marks both the general and partner sales sold out, and the Singapore Tourism Board's own announcement of the four-night run. 7 artsg.com. 8 Base Entertainment Asia confirms show and venue; the 16 February to 4 April range is from trade coverage — marinabaysands.com refuses this desk, so the closing date is not venue-verified. 9 Ticket Oosumo and the Japan Sumo Association's English site. 10 The National Art Center, Tokyo. 11 Roppongi Hills events listing. 12 tokyocomiccon.jp. 13 Sapporo official tourism. 14 marathon.tokyo. 15 ausopen.com. 16 artbasel.com. 17 christmaswonderland.sg, the Gardens by the Bay calendar, and a 404 on the attraction page, all read 26 September 2026. 18 hksevens.com; the Les Misérables run is documented in contemporaneous Singapore theatre coverage from March to May 2026. No event on this page is listed on the strength of an aggregator alone; several that appeared only on aggregators — and Chingay 2027, whose organiser still shows the 2026 edition — were dropped.

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

Four of the five are too new to call, and saying so is the review

One of the most-watched kitchens of the year opened on Friday. Nobody has eaten in it and filed yet — so here is what is actually known, and where the dissent is.

Árō opened on Friday at 15 Mohamed Sultan Road, in the shophouse that held Esora. It is **Johanne Siy**'s first restaurant under her own name — Pangasinan-born, trained through Le Bernardin, Café Boulud, Restaurant André, Noma, Relæn and Fäviken, most recently leading Lolla. She calls the format "Creator's Cuisine": ingredient-led rather than national, built on relationships with under-recognised Asia-Pacific producers, and she describes herself as "an agent who tells the stories of the communities behind the produce we use." The name fuses the Latin *arō*, to cultivate, with *áro* — love, in her hometown dialect.¹

Twenty-six seats, a counter of ten, tasting menu at **S\$268**. The opening menu runs gamet seaweed with oysters, pili-nut custard with jamón and caviar, stingless-bee honey with blue cheese, and a whole-globe *tibuok* salt against cucumber sorbet. Beverage is **Jhonel Faelnar**, late of Atomix; pastry **Elaine Ng**, late of La Dame de Pic; the room is Keiji Ashizawa. Thursday to Monday, closed Tuesday and Wednesday.¹

We held Árō out of yesterday's issue for want of a published review. A day later there is still not one: no Eatbook, no Time Out, no Michelin entry, nothing on HungryGoWhere. The anticipation around it is **reputational rather than reported** — a CV and an address. The same is true of three others below. That is not a gap in this page; on a weekend when four significant kitchens are under a week old, it is the honest state of the evidence, and a reader deciding where to spend \$268 deserves to be told which opinions exist and which do not.

Fico at Tanjong Beach Club opens tomorrow, 28 September, on Sentosa — chef-partner **Mirko Febbrile** for the Lo & Behold Group, and the one line on this page that carries transferable evidence: the East Coast original took a **Michelin Bib Gourmand**

within its first year and has held it. Pugliese coastal cooking around a two-metre charcoal dome; focaccina \$25–26, octopus \$38, a seafood platter \$108–198. Febbrile: "Where I'm from, the sun is an ingredient."²

And at the end of October, **Moutai House** takes all three storeys of the Fullerton Waterboat House — a venture between the baijiu producer, Imperial Treasure and the Nutmeg & Clove team, billed as the world's first Moutai brand space. Three hundred collectible labels including a **birth-year collection reaching back to 1965**, Huaiyang fine dining, a rooftop bar — and no published prices. Either the year's most interesting opening or its most expensive showroom.³

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE SOMEBODY ACTUALLY SAID NO

Two three-star reviews landed this month at one of the few outlets here still willing to print a score.

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE SOMEBODY ACTUALLY SAID NO

Two three-star reviews landed this month at one of the few outlets here still printing a score. On **Lombardo's Singapore**, the Amsterdam import's first franchise on Duxton Road: the fries are "light, crispy and perfumed," but the patty is "lacking a Maillard-approved crust." On **Corduroy Palace** at Amoy Street, a 300-bottle list and 21 vintage rugs: it "offers a chance to enter a glamorous world, dripping in hedonistic charm" — and then, of the \$50 caviar dumplings, "the delicate flavour of the fish egg is sadly lost to the vinegar-laced dressing."⁴ Neither opening date could be confirmed, so both run as reviews rather than as new openings.

TOO NEW TO CALL ×4

ONE BIB GOURMAND, TRANSFERRED

NO FORUM VOICE FOUND

SOURCES 1 Árō opening coverage and the restaurant's own reservation listing, read 26 September 2026; the menu, the price, the seat count and the Siy quotation are from announcement copy, and **no evaluative review of this restaurant exists at the time of writing**. 2 Fico at Tanjong Beach Club opening material and the Lo & Behold listing; the Bib Gourmand is the East Coast original's, awarded 2023 and held since. Two opening-week reviews published 23–26 September; one was reachable only through a syndication because the original outlet serves this desk a bot challenge. A grand-opening one-for-one ran 26–28 September, excluding the dessert counter. Whuchu opening coverage plus two listings round-ups; all descriptive, none evaluative. 3 Moutai House pre-opening material. Time Out Singapore reviews of Lombardo's and Corduroy Palace, both three stars out of five. 4 Time Out Singapore reviews of Lombardo's and Corduroy Palace, both three stars out of five. **No social or forum chatter appears on this page because none was found:** Reddit refused, Instagram is unreachable here, and three long-running Singapore food blogs carry no coverage of any of these venues.

THE UNDERCURRENT · BANGLADESH

Jhut

Bangladesh has run one of the largest circular economies on earth for forty years without anyone calling it that. Now Brussels has written rules that turn its cutting-floor scrap into a regulated feedstock — and the effect is an enclosure act.

The word is **झুট** — *jhut*, the trade term for what falls off a cutting table. Offcuts, clips, rejects, sweepings. Bangladesh’s garment industry shipped **\$38.7 billion** of clothing in the last financial year, four-fifths of everything the country exports, and in the making of it produced somewhere between **400,000 and 577,000 tonnes** of scrap.¹

Almost none of it is buried. It is swept into sacks, sold at the factory gate, and hand-sorted by roughly **200,000 people** — about seven in ten of them women — into grades that become T-shirts in Pabna, sweaters in Gaibandha, blankets in Bogura, rope, mattress stuffing and brick-kiln fuel. The share that cannot be sold at all — debris, broken bits of broom — is **five to ten per cent**.²

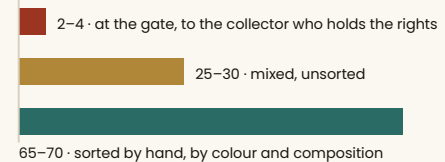
2–4

TAKA PER KILO THAT A FACTORY OWNER RECEIVES WHEN THE LOCAL COLLECTOR HOLDS THE RIGHTS — AGAINST A MARKET RATE OF **40**. HE IS NOT PERMITTED TO REFUSE³

That spread is the whole political economy in one line. The sorting itself creates the value: mixed unsorted offcuts move at **25 to 30 taka** a kilo, and the same material sorted by colour and composition at **65 to 70** — a two-to-threefold premium produced by nothing but hands and eyes. Grade one white knit clips reach 70 to 80; grade three polyester goes for two or three and some of it is burned.⁴

The women doing the sorting earn **200 to 260 taka a day** — ten-hour shifts, seven days, about 8,000 taka a month. Ninety-four per cent have only a verbal agreement. Four per cent belong to a union. **None has social security**. One woman in her forties, asked what happens if the machine takes a hand, said the owner pays for the treatment and you lose both the hand and the job.⁵

WHAT A KILO OF JHUT IS WORTH, IN TAKA



A Meridian chart. Sources: Roskilde research brief, 2025; Bangladeshi trade press, 18 May

The whole value of the trade is added by hands, between the second bar and the third.

Europe destroys between 264,000 and 594,000 tonnes of unsold textiles a year. Bangladesh sweeps up between 400,000 and 577,000. The two numbers are the same size.

Two forces are now arriving at once to take this trade over, and neither is the one the reader would expect.

THE SECOND FORCE · THE RENT DID NOT DISAPPEAR, IT CHANGED HANDS

Collection rights have long been held by politically affiliated local collectors — the academic phrasing is that the trade is controlled “to a high degree” by them, and a United Nations industrial-development coordinator in Dhaka calls it a very opaque chain with limited visibility. The fall of the government in August 2024 did not abolish that rent. It reassigned it. Since then there have been **more than fifty violent clashes** over jhut control across the industrial belts. The president of the knitwear association says the field-level network is largely the same people, with new spheres of influence, and that many factory owners lack even the freedom to decide who buys their own scrap.⁶

SOURCES 1 Export figures from the garment manufacturers’ own export-performance page: \$38.70bn, 80.62 per cent of \$48.00bn total merchandise exports, down 1.64 per cent year on year. The waste tonnage range is the one used in the academic literature, citing two separate estimates; sources across the trade give 400,000, 440,000, 500,000, 577,000 and 600,000 tonnes depending on year and method, which is why a range is printed rather than a figure. 2 Worker numbers, the cluster geography and the five-to-ten per cent residue from a Roskilde University research brief of May 2025, built on 43 interviews conducted between February 2022 and May 2024 in the Mirpur, Narayanganj, Gazipur and Pabna clusters. 3 Reported in the Bangladeshi press, 26 October 2025. 4 The 2025 grade ladder from the same research brief; the 2026 sorted-versus-unsorted spread from a Bangladeshi trade publication of 18 May 2026. 5 Workforce conditions from a March 2026 study by a circular-economy organisation with two Bangladeshi partners, fieldwork February to June 2024; the quoted worker account from a Bangladeshi newspaper feature of 17 September 2026. European Commission, on the destruction ban entering application, and Regulation (EU) 2024/1781. The 2030 date for the textile digital product passport is not stated on the Commission pages this desk read and is therefore described rather than cited. 6 The political-control finding from the Roskilde brief; the UN coordinator’s characterisation from an April 2025 report; the count of clashes and the association president’s remarks from a Bangladeshi business daily, 23 June 2026.

The violence is not abstract and it is not adults. On **9 April 2026**, at half past nine in the morning, three people were shot at Chandni Housing in Fatullah during a fight between two youth-wing factions over the scrap from a single factory. One of them was **thirteen years old**, hit in the abdomen. A police officer explained that one group had controlled the unloading there for the previous eighteen months. A district official for one of the factions said the incident was not political: **“it is entirely business-related.”**¹

Two months earlier, in Ashulia, a **sixteen-year-old** was shot in the back during a shootout between factions of the same party while scrap was being moved. In March, eight were injured including a journalist at an export-processing zone. In April another ten outside a factory in Kaliakair. Between early August and early October last year, thirty people were injured in fifteen clashes, and fifty-seven per cent of businesses surveyed said extortion had increased.²

17

MINISTRIES AND AGENCIES WHOSE APPROVALS A GARMENT FACTORY REQUIRES, PER A 2013 TRANSPARENCY STUDY — WHICH IS THE SUPPLY SIDE OF THE MARKET FOR PROTECTION³

There is an academic name for the arrangement. Ahmed, Alawattage and Jayasinghe call it **mastanocracy** — “a hybrid political formation of violent criminal governance that operates legitimately at the nexus of corruption, democratic erosion, elite power and social polarization” — built from eighty interviews across five industrial zones. What makes their paper hard to dismiss is that the owners are not victims in it. One tells them: **“It may sound disturbing, but mastans are a blessing... they are a thousand times better than the so-called government employees.”** Another: “Survival without mastans is unthinkable in Bangladesh.”³

A shirt sold in Europe with thirty per cent recycled cotton on the label is, at the moment, a claim about paperwork.

Which brings us to the enclosure. The formal channel being built — brands, a UN agency, the European Union, an Estonian traceability platform — routes specified cotton waste directly between factories and recyclers, in the words of the researcher who studied it, **“completely circumventing the informal jhuth handling clusters.”** Only **one to five per cent** of jhuth currently moves that way, though it is growing fast. The country’s recycling capacity is **18,000 to 24,000 tonnes a year against 330,000 to 500,000 tonnes** of suitable waste — five to seven per cent — and over half the material leaves the country raw.⁴

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT INSIDE BANGLADESH

The formalisation case is being made locally, not imposed. A director of the manufacturers’ association has called for designated collection points, fixed pricing and **mandatory trade licences** for anyone collecting textile waste — which would license the informal collectors out of existence. And foreign capital is already building: a Chinese firm signed in November 2024 to invest **\$35.03 million** in an export zone turning jhuth into 20,000 tonnes of yarn a year, employing 600 people.⁵

THE SCEPTIC · AND SHE IS NOT THE PERSON YOU WOULD EXPECT

The sharpest dissent comes from a Danish researcher inside the sustainability world. **Lone Riisgaard** of Roskilde University makes four findings that cut against the entire programme. The premise that Bangladeshi jhuth is landfilled or incinerated **“is not always backed by empirical evidence”** — hence the five-to-ten per cent residue. Recycled yarn typically runs a **maximum of 30 to 40 per cent recycled fibre**, so sixty to seventy per cent is still virgin, and fibres degrade each cycle. One industry expert she interviewed put the fear plainly: “A big concern is that history repeats itself.”⁶

SOURCES 1 Bangladeshi daily press report of the Fatullah shooting, 9 April 2026, naming the three wounded, the factory and the police account. 2 The Ashulia shooting of 9 February 2025 and the Narayanganj clash of 6 March 2025, both from Bangladeshi business-press reports carrying the police confirmations; the Kaliakair clash of 21 April 2026; the extortion survey figures from a Bangladeshi daily of 26 October 2025, which also carries the Dhaka Chamber president’s account of being made to sell scrap at half price. One further clash reported in May 2026 is omitted because the outlet refused this desk and it could not be read at source. 3 Ahmed, Alawattage and Jayasinghe, “Mastanocracy: the legitimization of criminal governance and violence in Bangladesh’s garment industry,” *Human Relations* 79(8), published online 17 October 2025, read as the open-access manuscript; eighty interviews of twenty to a hundred and forty minutes, plus focus groups and observation, over six months. The seventeen-approval figure is the transparency study it cites. 4 The traceability platform’s role and the one-to-five per cent share from the Roskilde brief; the capacity and export figures from a trade report of 3 September 2024 on a study conducted by a German development agency with a major retailer. That study’s own PDF refused this desk and is cited at one remove. 5 The association director’s licensing proposal, reported 7 May 2026; the national strategy and its consultation of 23 April 2026; the Chinese investment agreement of 3 November 2024. 6 Riisgaard, research brief no. 1, *Climate Change and Global Value Chains in Bangladesh*, May 2025, read as a PDF in full.

So here is the argument, stated plainly. **The circular economy is not arriving in Bangladesh. It is being taken from Bangladesh.** The country has been doing circularity for forty years at a scale Europe is only now legislating toward, using an infrastructure of two hundred thousand pairs of hands. What the new rules do is select the five to seven per cent of that material which is clean, cotton and standardisable — the fraction that can be documented — and route it to industrial recyclers with brand-approved paperwork.

The rest is left behind: the blends, the small pieces, the grade-two and grade-three material that only a human being can sort. And the informal sector's economics depended on cross-subsidy from exactly the valuable fraction now being removed. You do not need to intend harm to cause it. You need only to define "circular" as "traceable" and then take the traceable part.

Sustainability compliance is becoming a mechanism for deciding which poor people are inside a supply chain and which are outside it — and the decision is made in Brussels, on the basis of documentation rather than of benefit.

This is what makes the story worth a reader's attention four thousand miles away. Every large economy is now writing disclosure regimes — for carbon, for supply chains, for provenance — and each of them shares the same hidden property: **a rule written in the language of documentation will always favour whoever is already documented.** The informal sector is not, by definition. It is not being outcompeted. It is being defined out.

There is a second, harder honesty here, and it belongs to the people making the rules as much as to their critics: **nobody has demonstrated that the new channel is greener than the old one.** Not that it is worse — that it has not been shown to be better. Recycled yarn is still sixty to seventy per cent virgin

fibre. The scrap Europe is regulating Bangladesh to account for is very nearly the same tonnage Europe itself destroys unsold every year. The measurable change so far is in who holds the paperwork, and therefore who holds the margin.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE THE VERDICT

Three tests, all of them answerable. **One:** a published life-cycle comparison between the traceable channel and the informal clusters, on the same material. Riisgaard asked for exactly this, and asked for it *before* the appropriation rather than after. **Two:** a transition mechanism that pays the sorters — the Circle Economy study that counted them was explicitly a "just transition" document, and a Bangladeshi climate researcher has already made the point that a factory can become greener while a sorting worker becomes poorer. **Three:** whether the national strategy due by the end of this year licenses the collectors or absorbs them. The manufacturers' association has proposed mandatory trade licences. Two hundred thousand people with verbal contracts and no social security will not be issued licences.¹

THE COUNTER-CASE · WHERE THIS ARGUMENT COULD BE WRONG

Three ways. **The informal system may be worse than its defenders allow** — the five-to-ten per cent residue figure comes from one researcher's fieldwork in four clusters, not a national audit, and the brick-kiln fuel end of the trade is combustion, not recycling. **The formal channel may not scale at all:** speakers at an industry event in May noted that chemical recycling still lacks a viable business case, that about half the country's waste is blended fibre that cannot re-enter the export garment chain, and that recycled goods meet consumer resistance on price. An enclosure that fails is a different problem from one that succeeds. A country in that position is entitled to want the formal channel, whoever it displaces.²

Which is the uncomfortable shape of it. The rules are not malicious, the money is not imaginary, and the people who will lose are not anybody's enemy — they are simply undocumented, in a system that has just made documentation the unit of virtue. **Three women sit on a blue tarpaulin with hand shears, sorting pale blue from pink, and produce a two-to-threefold increase in the value of the material in front of them.** No passport will record that. It is, by the new definition, not circular at all.

SOURCES 1 The life-cycle test is Riisgaard's own first recommendation in the May 2025 brief. The worker count and the just-transition framing are from *Making the Invisible Visible*, published 11 March 2026 by a circular-economy organisation with the Bangladesh University of Textiles and two local partners; the greener-factory-poorer-worker argument is a Bangladeshi climate researcher's, published 18 September 2026. The licensing proposal was reported 7 May 2026. 2 The industry-event caveats on chemical recycling, blended fibre and consumer price resistance were reported 7 May 2026. The \$4–5 billion foregone-earnings figure and the fifteen per cent import reduction come from a study by a German development agency with a major retailer; its own PDF refused this desk, so both are cited at one remove, and a separate think-tank estimate puts the saving at \$500 million against another's \$700 million — the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

Filed under footnote nine

Singapore became a super-aged society on Thursday afternoon. The document that recorded it put the threshold in a footnote and did not use the phrase in its own headline text. Twenty-one point four per cent, against a line of twenty-one, and no bell.

It was that kind of week for thresholds nobody announced. A rule restricting polysilicon imports took effect two days before it was published, setting a new importer's weekly allowance at twelve kilogrammes. The longest number-one run in the history of the Hot 100 spent the same seven days at number two in Britain. A cyclone split the most photographed railway in Asia ten months ago and the trains still stop an hour out of Colombo, which almost nobody planning the trip has been told.

And in Fatullah, on a Thursday morning in April, a thirteen-year-old was shot in a fight over who would unload the sacks of offcuts outside a clothing factory. A local official was careful to explain that the incident was not political. It was entirely business-related.

Europe now forbids destroying unsold clothes, and asks the countries that make them to document where the scraps went. Two hundred thousand people sort those scraps by hand, on verbal contracts, and cannot be documented. The rule is not aimed at them. It does not need to be.

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A note on method. This edition was researched with working network access, and the load-bearing figures were read on the pages that carry them — the Bureau of Industry and Security's own rule in the Federal Register, the Federal Reserve's statement, the US Treasury's par yield curve, *Population in Brief 2026* as a PDF, Sri Lanka Railways' recovery bulletin, the immigration department's own visa portal, Platinum's engineering page, Hakase's price list, a merged pull request's benchmark tables, and the Official Charts Company. **Reddit refused this desk on every route tried, including nine mirrors, and Beesource sits behind a payment wall** — so several desks in this issue carry no forum voice at all, and say so where that matters. **Also refused:** Reuters, Bloomberg, AP, CNBC, CNN, *The Straits Times*, *Business Times*, CNA, TripAdvisor, Instagram, billboard.com, bmj.com, sagepub, ScienceDirect, Metacritic, *Pitchfork*, marinabaysands.com, imda.gov.sg, moe.gov.sg, esafety.gov.au, and the six largest Western news domains at the search layer. Nothing in this issue is attributed to any of them. Wikimedia returned 429 to every direct route until a thumbnail host answered; every photograph in the Photo Edition was opened and looked at before it was captioned. **Where a number could not be read at source it is flagged as held, and where only one source carried it, it is flagged as single-sourced.** Two figures printed in No. 114 are corrected inside: Friday's ten-year yield, and the chart on which a twenty-third week at number one was scored.